



ALL ABOUT MALTESE

COMPLETE MALTESE GUIDE
BEGINNER TO ADVANCED
1 - 8 WORKOUT LEVELS

YORDAN STANCHEV

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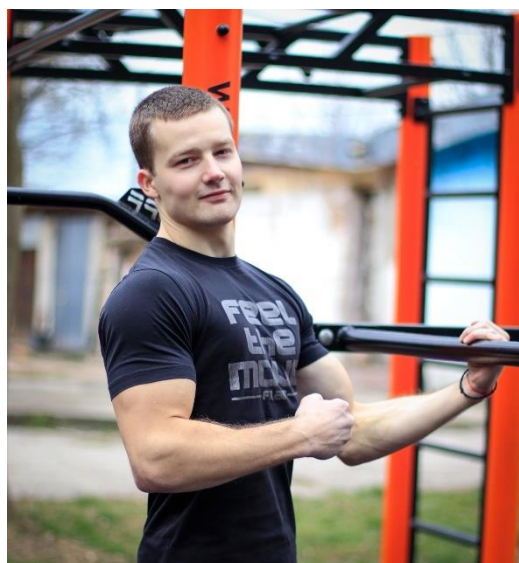
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1. About me and this e-book

Hello, guys!

My name is Yordan Stanchev. I am street workout/calisthenics athlete, judge and coach. I've got over 10 years of street workout and calisthenics experience behind my back. Everything has started even before these 10 years, for which I'm talking about. From 10 years I just know about street workout as a sport. Since I was young I used to love to practice push ups whenever I want, all kind of variations. At age of 10 I already was able to do one arm push ups and at least 5 sets x 30 push ups as a regular training.



Probably that has built some fundamental strength in my body, so first when I tried to perform my first pull ups ever, I did 11 in one set, at age of 11 and I thought I could be actually good in that thing. Some days later I found the thing I practice it's called street workout and watched some Bulgarian athletes, doing different muscle ups, handstand and front lever variations and for 2 years since then I was doing only that, I was considering this to be my threshold, until I started to compete.

After the first competition on which I have ever competed, I was disappointed from myself, because my high expectations met the reality, I was 7th from 38 participants and that wasn't quite enough for me. I was always aiming to the top and then actually everything has started. I put myself under suicide workouts every day, without to think how to rest, without to think how to recover, how to structure the routines, I was lucky I was only 15 years old and the recovery itself was fast. But the thing I'm trying to say is – I've done many mistakes through the years of my calisthenics journey, which is far from that to end and there are many things which I realized I mustn't do. That's why I'm here to help to those people who have the same questions as me in the beginning, but with the answers which I may give, based on my mistakes. After all - failure is the greatest teacher, right?

There are many things, which I want to tell you and I will try to look max deep in the details, in order to be easier for you understand any single word as you are performing the basics/elements by your own and to figure out faster how to think like a planche creator.

For those who are reading this e-book just know all of this content is done by me and everything is tested, because I'm that kind of person who's taking notes only by my own mistakes and I have to experience something to know is it true or not.

2. What Maltese actually is

Maltese is a pushing static element, which is positioning the whole of your body in horizontal position (exception: arms), while your grip is wider twice the width of your shoulders (we'll discuss that more in details later), requires months of work and consistency, sometimes even years if we don't know how to workout for it. It's known in gymnastics also as "swallow" and "samolet"/"самолет" in Bulgarian and Russian, of course the pronounce is different. In most of the cases it's harder than regular full planche, but it depends for which element you are working harder, because in general – they are not that much strictly related.

For Maltese can be said it's a symbol of strength in the pushing static skills. The element is highly valued and also can give you good points from any judges in a competition, if you execute it in the way it should be done. It's not a coincidence why so many athletes, who have mastered this element to such a level and can play with it in different combos - they are considered as ones of the strongest calisthenic athletes.

3. Maltese muscle engagement

The muscle engagement depends from what kind of Maltese variation we are performing, that's why it's hard to give certain number for the ratio of the muscle engagement.

Generally the active muscles are the same like for planche, just their activity is on different level:



Figure 3. 1 – Planche related muscles

We can say the most active muscles in the order of their importance:

1. Trapezius
2. Shoulders
3. Serratus Anterior
4. Biceps/triceps
5. Infraspinatus (part of the rotator cuff)
6. Forearms (because of the grip)
7. Lower back
8. Abs

According to some researches – these 8 muscle groups are acting together in order to reach balance in the shoulder's joint and the result is Maltese hold. It's hard to say a certain percentage of activation for each muscle group, because it really depends on what are you more focused.



Figure 3. 2 – Maltese related muscles

I can agree with that statement, because during my experience with Maltese holds I noticed when you don't keep the right balance with the tension between the engaged muscles in your body something goes wrong. Either your form will change, either your shoulder will fall down. Everything has to be well balanced and understood.

Important note: I know a lot of you may ask why the lats and the back shoulders aren't colored as active muscles. I would put them as more supportive muscles and their activation is not truly necessary. If you aim for a certain form – yes, they might be even more active than the showed muscles here, it depends from the person.

4. With what we can mistake Maltese?

There are two cases when Maltese can be mistaken - if the shoulder's level is too high or when it's too low.

The first case is - do we do Maltese on vertical poles or back lever with intention for Maltese? The first thing we should watch if someone is performing low Maltese is – are the shoulders higher, on the same level or lower than the grip level. If it's lower – here we talk about wide back lever. It's that simple. From now on you know this fundamental difference and you can apply it whenever you have to analyze someone's Maltese execution. Here you can see the difference in details if we put a horizontal line between the grip:



Figure 4.1 – Wide back lever on vertical poles (mistaken Maltese)

Above on **Figure 4.1** we see typical example for mistaken Maltese with wide back lever. The line starts from the middle of the wrists and is crossing the middle of the shoulder.

Below on **Figure 4.2** is shown the right execution of Maltese. Just right shoulder's level, slightly above the line.

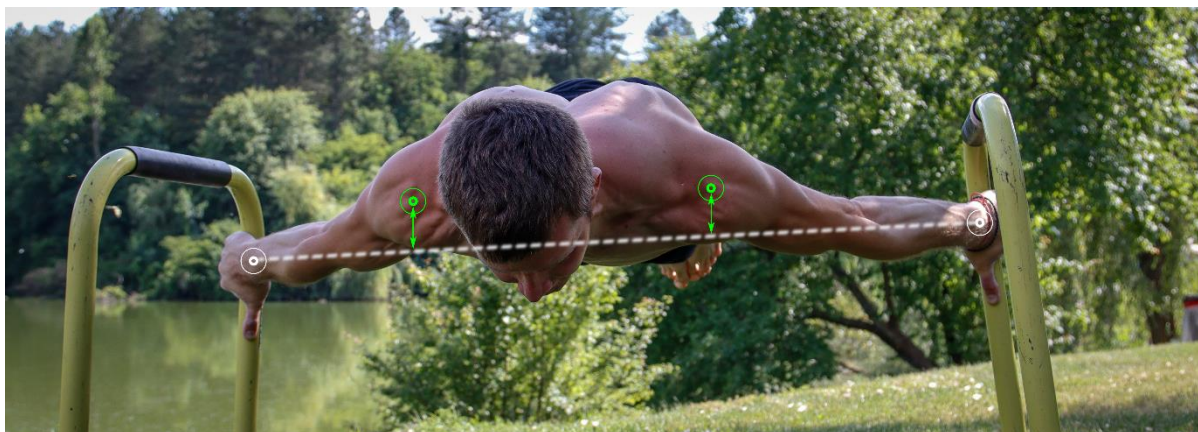


Figure 4.2 – Correct Maltese on vertical poles

It's important to note in these 2 examples – on the first picture the posture I used is retraction, while on the second one is more neutral type scapula position. Even if the posture is protraction while the shoulder's level is below the wrist – the element still remains to be back lever.

This rule applies for any kind of Maltese. Not only on vertical poles, but with neutral grip on parallettes as well – watch for the same details.

If you are not familiar with what is protraction and retraction here you can see an example:

Retraction



Protraction



Figure 4.3 – Scapular postures – retraction and protraction

The second possibility to mistake Maltese is with wide planche. I'm explaining my theory there, because there isn't a strict definition anywhere among the SW community. Gymnasts can give their definition, but we practice different sport and our equipment is also different, our goals are different as well, that's why we can't take it as face value.

According to the gymnastics rules – Maltese is done when shoulders reach the grip level or are just a bit higher – in case if Maltese is performed on floor (with a few centimeters difference).

As you can obviously see their rule has an exception. We are different from gymnasts in terms of goals and competition regulations. It's logical to put our standards as well, at least that's how I think.

If you see somewhere a double dip bar - that's your standard for Maltese. It's double the shoulder's width or further. We can do safely leaned push ups there, otherwise if we try it wider we almost won't have an opportunity to keep the wrists higher than the parallettes. It will be also extremely hard to perform high level Maltese combinations as "push up + press". Twice or more the shoulder's width is okay as an indication – do we have got Maltese or not, if we apply tension for lower Maltese of course.

If we apply double the shoulder's width with intention for less lean and higher position – even twice the shoulder's width will end as a wide planche look. It has to be balanced. In some cases Maltese vision depends from the lean level. **Once again I'm saying – that's my definition and understanding, it's nothing official, because I grew up with this element.**



Figure 4.4 – Maltese grip width (twice the shoulder's level)

The next question there will be – “Okay, what if it's too high, we were talking exactly about the height in the beginning, not about the width”. Exactly! The width can make the level either lower, either higher. Let's take dead planche as example, if we count it as the gymnastics rule – that's Maltese. The difference is that – in street workout we do have dead planche! Gymnasts are executing Maltese mainly on rings and there they can change the Maltese width whenever they wish. That's another fundamental we have to keep in mind – in most case our equipment does not allow us to regulate the width that easily, Dragon Maltese here is exception.

What else do we have? Different level lean range for each element. You can start with full planche and if you keep leaning even 2-3 more fists forward from you start full planche position – it's still a full planche. If you start from wide back lever and you try to push more and more higher like again – 2 or 3 more fists higher then you are still in back lever, not in Maltese. You see compared with the other elements people try to act truly strict when it comes a question for Maltese. I've been doing Maltese for 7 years already and when I see someone in social media explaining how it has to be done, excuse me but that means I would never be able to test my max hold if I have to follow these rules.

If there are any wonders how we can call Maltese with grip and shoulders aligned – we can use the gymnastics term – Maltese cross. That's from me about this topic.



Figure 4.5 – Maltese Cross

5. Specific Maltese warm up.

Just like for any other kind of sport activity you have to start with neck rotations, wrist rotations, elbows rotations and shoulder rotations – once without applying any tension and once with applying tension. In short – you need to start with some dynamics moves for the joints.

Next you have to stretch your lower back. There are plenty of exercises for preparing the lower back, I'm choosing to prepare mine by bending the upper body forward and backward. Also move bend your upper body while you are forming a circle with it. Many people probably have done it in the physical education classes at school.

Something very useful for your back health is the cow-cat stretch. On **Figure 5.1** is illustrated the circle of the protraction/retraction switch + motion of the pelvis. Each position has to be held for at least 3 seconds. Try to coordinate the breathing with the move of the chest. Cow position focused on stretching the back and exhaling while you are pushing your body higher, while the cat position focused on pulling the lower back and chest down while you are breathing in.

Cow stretch is strength based. **Cat stretch** is mobility based.

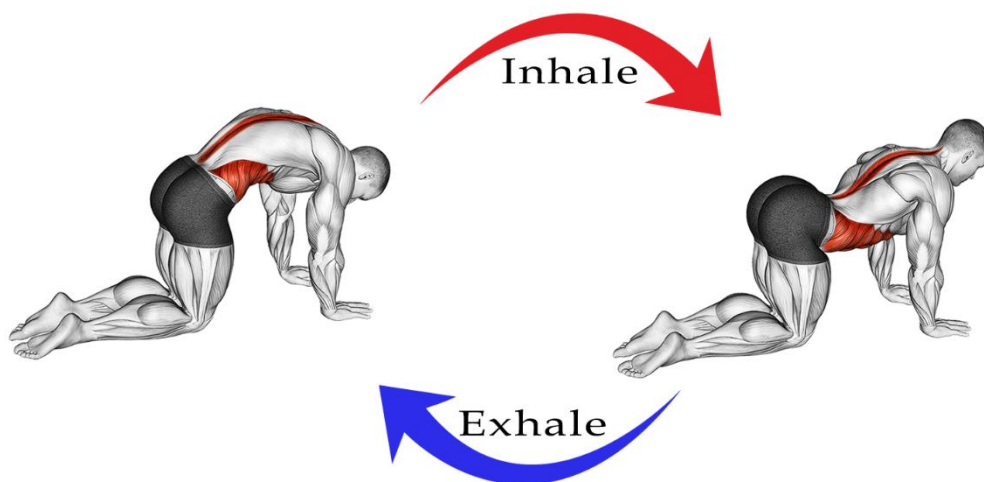


Figure 5.1 – Cow-cat stretch

Neck holds in standing position is the thing we shouldn't avoid, because of the attached trapezoidal muscle to it. By doing stretches with the neck with a few seconds hold we are preparing the trapezoid for the loading that's about to experience. As we said the trapezoid is with the highest percentage of activation if we do it correctly, so it needs a special treatment.

Until now that was the basic warm up which everybody knows, but we can't start without it, that's why I have to mention it. Now comes the specific warm up with the stretches and specific joint rotation we all need before to start with the Maltese practice.

SPECIFIC WARM UP

Here I will show you specific and complex stretches, which in my opinion are the best to prepare your body for the loading of the Maltese hold and will save some time.

SUPINATED WRIST PUSH



Figure 5.2 - Wrist push - supination

Supinated wrist push stretching is a great way to start your specific warm up. I use it often before to start with the execution of my own routines. That's an exercise which can be executed on the ground only and in the following way:

- Step 1.** Rotate your arms so your palm to look forward (1st picture from **Figure 5.2**).
- Step 2.** Place your palms on the ground and apply force against the floor. You have to be a slightly leaned forward (2nd picture from **Figure 5.2**).
- Step 3.** Start to push with the upper part of your palm (which is right under your finger) – in other words place more of your bodyweight there. From the leaned position while you are flexed in this way – try to slowly bring back the lean. Until you finish as it's shown on the third picture from **Figure 5.2**.

While you are transferring between Step 2 and Step 3 you have to feel your inner forearm and the long head of the bicep stretched. Meanwhile you are preparing with over supination your upper wrist area for loading as well. It would feel even better in your warm up if you finish this exercise in leaned position with 5 seconds hold, but with near max pushed chest up and 80% flexed biceps.

CAUTION: You mustn't feel any pain while you are executing it. Don't overdo it! Each overdone stretch – no matter where can be harmful. You have to feel tolerable stretch, max close to the threshold with the pain.

I would recommend 2 sets x 7 reps.

Shoulder's preparation:

FRONT SHOULDER STRETCHING



Figure 5.3 – Front shoulder stretching

As we all know tendons are the most important part of the muscle integrity. Bicep can be torn most of the cases either from the upper or either from the lower bicep tendon, it's a one on a million case when it's possible to tear the bicep from the middle, from the muscle part (as it almost happened with mine). As I am used to say – “the bicep is one of the most miserable areas from the whole body”. That's why we should never skip the safety for any of the bicep tendons. With this exercise we have to extend our bicep tendons and the front shoulder. It has to be executed in the following way:

- Step 1.** Catch with pronated grip any bar which is somewhere under the shoulder level, similar like to the height of the bar from the first picture from **Figure 5.3**.
- Step 2.** Rotate your body in the opposite direction of the bar, until the grip is switched to supinated. Align your feet. Let a bit the free shoulder to be in front of the shoulder with the busy arm.
- Step 3.** Push slowly your chest forward and let your busy shoulder a bit more backward. Hold in this way for 20 - 40 seconds. Repeat it 2 -3 times.

CAUTION: You mustn't feel any pain while you are executing it. Don't overdo it! Each overdone stretch – no matter where can be harmful. You have to feel tolerable stretch, max close to the threshold with the pain.

ANOTHER ANGLE OF FRONT SHOULDER STRETCHING



Figure 5.4 – Side shoulder stretching

Here we have another way of preparing the shoulders and biceps, but this time using a neutral grip, instead of pronated grip for bar. Like that we prepare our arms for another angle of stretching and loading. Execution:

- Step 1.** Stand next to a vertical column and place your palm a bit below the shoulder's height, adjust it as your mobility allows. Like it's shown on the first picture from **Figure 5.4**.
- Step 2.** Rotate your body on 90° from the column and align your feet.
- Step 3.** Push slowly forward with the lower back and the chest. Hold in this way for 20 - 40 seconds. Repeat it 2 -3 times.

CAUTION: You mustn't feel any pain while you are executing it. Don't overdo it! Each overdone stretch – no matter where can be harmful. You have to feel tolerable stretch, max close to the threshold with the pain.

NEUTRAL BICEPS STRETCHING



Figure 5.5 – Neutral bicep stretching

It's time to pay more attention to the bicep. Here we have to use a bar once again, but this time on lower level. The between this exercise here and the stretching for the shoulder is the final position and the angle of the shoulder rotation. Instead of pushing the shoulder lower and forward, this time we have to push it backward and to rotate the elbow more towards our body. Like that the accent will be focused more on the bicep.

- Step 1.** Stay a shoe distance from the low bar and grab it with neutral grip - it's neutral grip, because of the body position. Like it's shown on the 1st picture from **Figure 5.5**.
- Step 2.** Fall on the knee, which is next to the bar, while you are keeping tight grip all the time, without releasing it. You should feel you whole hand squeezing the bar.
- Step 3.** Slowly push forward with your shoulder and chest. Hold in this way for 20 - 40 seconds. Repeat it 2 -3 times.

CAUTION: You mustn't feel any pain while you are executing it. Don't overdo it! Each overdone stretch – no matter where can be harmful. You have to feel tolerable stretch, max close to the threshold with the pain.

COMPLEXIVE DELTOIDS STRETCHING + LOWER BACK ACTIVATION

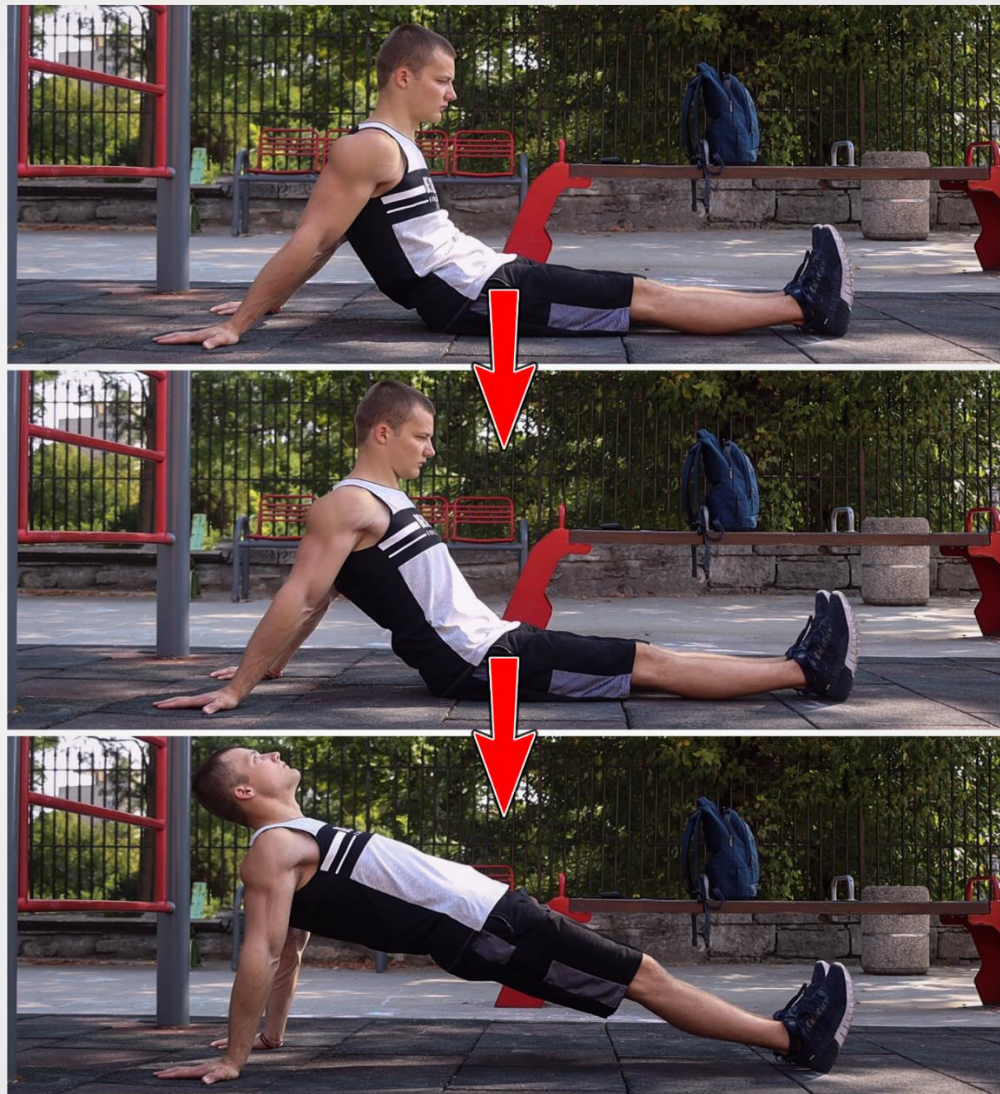


Figure 5.6 – Complexive deltoids stretching + lower back activation

Here another way to put biceps and shoulders in motion at once. The difference is we need only floor as assist for it.

- Step 1. Sit on the ground and extend your legs forward. Lean yourself on your hands so the angle to be between 60 – 90°, it depends from your flexibility level (1st picture on **Figure 5.6**). Take a deep breath.
- Step 2. Push slowly your chest forward and bring your shoulders backward. Exhale 1/3 of your breath.
- Step 3. Now while you are slowly leaning more on your arms – extend your lower back higher until you complete a straight line. When you reach it – flex your glutes and legs as well. Release the remained air from your lungs. Hold as much as you can.

I would recommend 2 sets x 3 repetitions of the whole activation.

STANDING EXTERNAL SHOULDER ROTATION WITH RUBBER BAND



Figure 5.7 – Standing external shoulder rotation with rubber band

I choose for myself one exercise to keep my rotator cuff in condition. I do and the internal shoulder rotation, but here I'm going to explain only the external one, because it's a bit more specific from the internal.

- Step 1. Align your feet next to the object, where your rubber band is tied. Feet spread – same as the shoulder's width. Retract your scapula (chest forward, shoulders - backward) and grab the rubber band in the same way like it's shown on the first picture from **Figure 5.7**.
- Step 2. While keeping the elbow touched to the ribs – pull the rubber band in the opposite direction of the bar base (external shoulder rotation).
- Step 3. When you do the whole movement hold for 2 seconds, like on the seconds picture of **Figure 5.7**.

I would recommend 2 sets x 8 reps.

ELBOW'S PREPARATION



Figure 5.8 – Elbows preparation

This exercise will be a good way to prepare your arms for the tension of doing Maltese. Included muscles: shoulder, bicep, tricep, forearm.

- Step 1. In standing position lift the arm which you are going to prepare first somewhere near the chest position and let it be almost locked, but not fully. The arm has to be orientated in supinated position.
- Step 2. Place your free arm's palm on the forearm of the almost extended arm and start to apply tension with it. You have to feel how your shoulder, bicep, tricep and grip are resisting on not going lower. Exactly like on the first picture from **Figure 5.8**.
- Step 3. While relaxing the bicep a bit and engaging the tricep more – extend fully your arm. Second picture of **Figure 5.8**.

I would recommend 2 sets x 8 reps.

Important: Keep your muscle activation in the first stance of **Figure 5.8** around 60%. When you go for the transition between slightly bent arm and fully extended arm – reduce the activation of the bicep to 40% and keep pushing with the tricep, until you fully extend the arm.

CAUTION: DON'T DO ANYTHING RECKLESS, EVERY MOVE MUST BE DONE SLOWLY AND CONTROLLED. EVERYTHING MUST COME FROM SLOW MUSCLE ACTIVATION AND YOU HAVE TO BE AWARE WITH DOING IT.

PROTRACTION AND RETRACTION SWITCHES ON KNEES

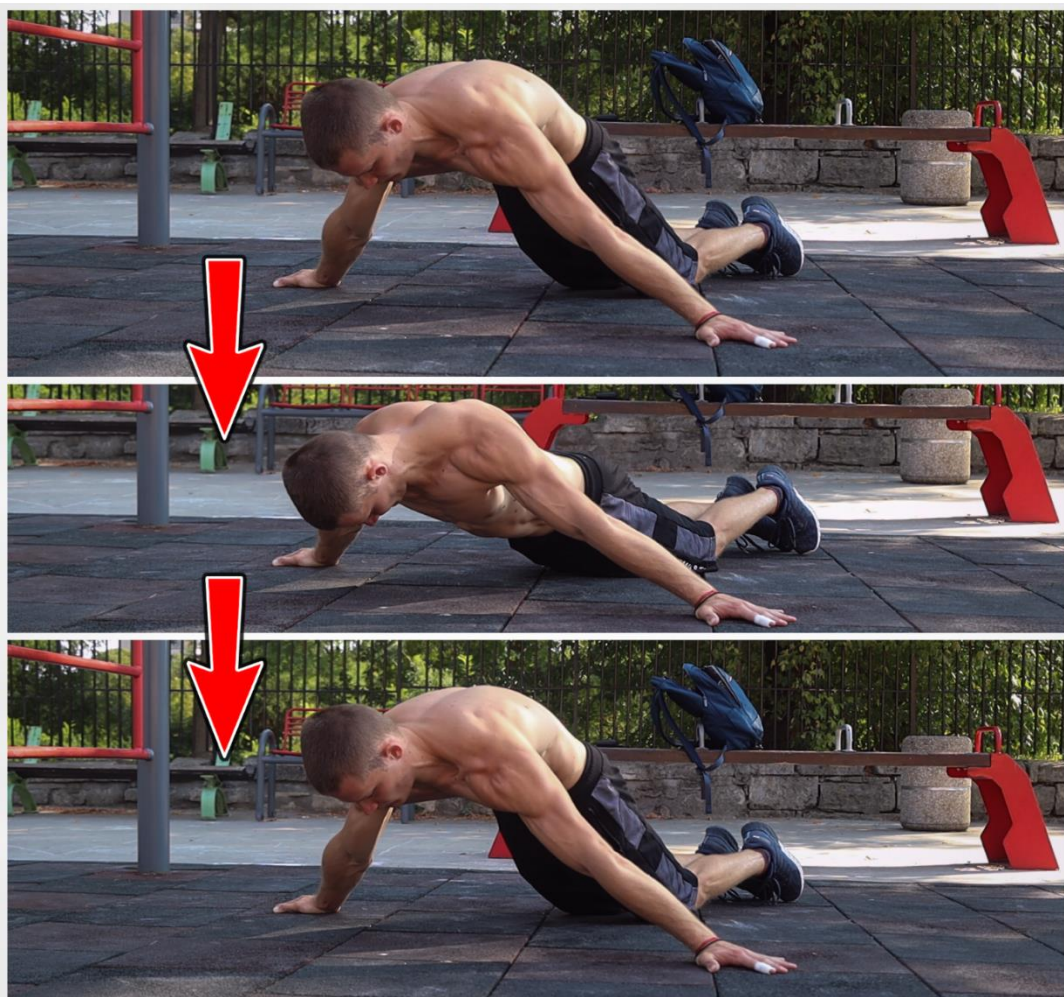


Figure 5.9 – Protraction and retraction switches on knees

The main purpose of retraction and protraction switches is to prepare your body and to keep you aware of the right posture, which you have to maintain during the Maltese basics, holds or combos you are about to perform. I choose on knee for easier start for you and easier execution in order to understand the right technique, BUT... There is possibility for some people this exercise to be harder on knees, instead on their feet. If you feel this

way, while you are experimenting with it – you can go straight on your feet with this exercise.

The specific is the following: while you are protracting – you are pushing higher and back as much as possible, while you are retracting – your body is leaning a bit forward, so if there's a wonder why you finish forward – it has to be like that.

- Step 1. Take protracted stance on your knees with grip twice wider or more of the shoulder's width. Like on the first picture from **Figure 5.9**. – Here the tension has to be equal between all the muscles, same as usual when you do Maltese. You must feel the chest raised as higher as possible. You may try to stretch your back upwards as well, that will support the protraction, it's a personal choice.
- Step 2. Here we go lower with chest, by increasing a bit the lean level forward. While you are going lower – start to inhale. You have to feel how you are unable to activate your trapezoid as usual, because of the incorrect stance you are getting in. Here you have to rely mostly on your grip and lower back to keep you standing. When you feel your chest relaxed – hold for 2 seconds. Second picture from **Figure 5.9**.
- Step 3. From max deep position start pushing your chest back to the highest point, if it's possible even a bit higher than when it was in main position. While you are pushing the chest higher – start to exhale. When you reach the top position don't stop the push, keep it and hold in that position for 2 seconds. Like on 3rd picture from **Figure 5.9**.

REGULAR PROTRACTION AND RETRACTION SWITCHES

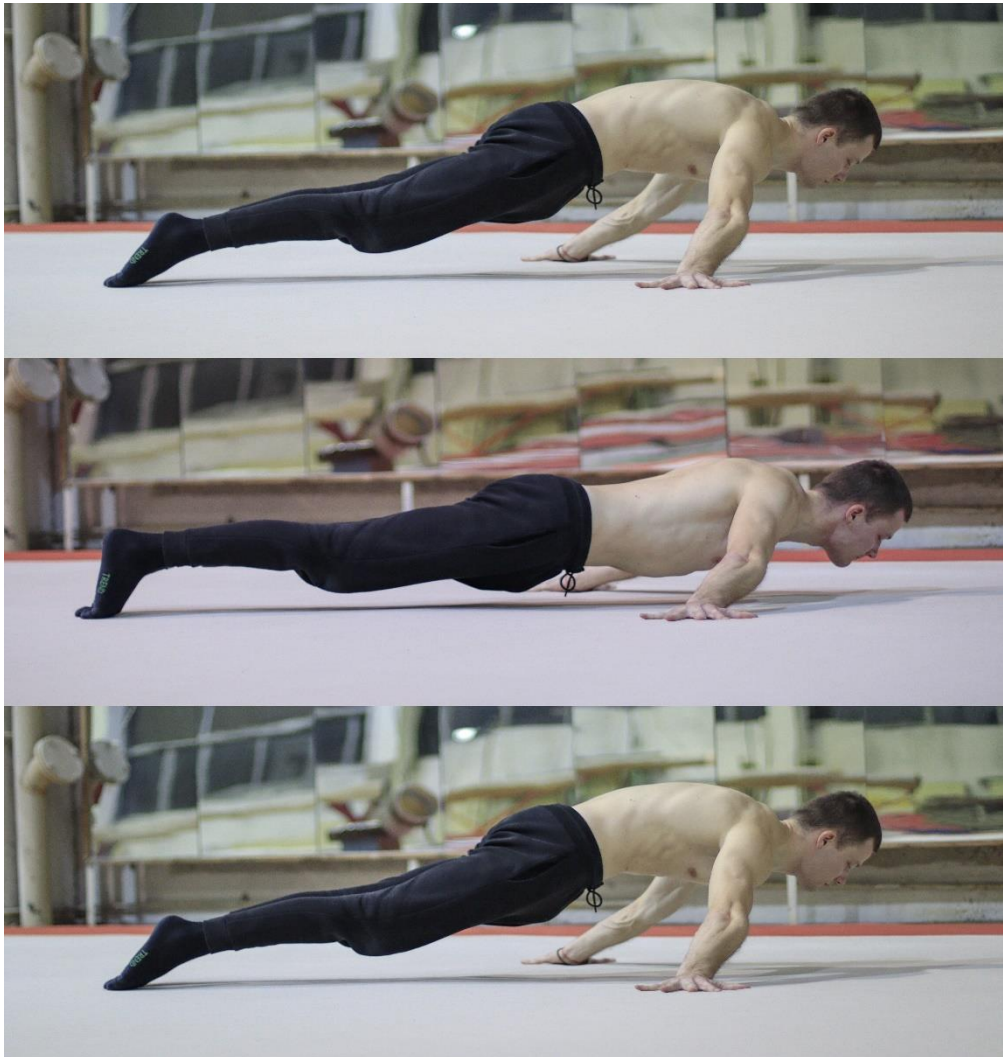


Figure 5.10 – Regular protraction and retraction switches

It's the same like the previous exercise, the difference is the assistance with toes, instead of knees. Here the required complexity of the body is more advanced and the feet can be used better to push forward, when you protract and to absorb the weight of your body, while there's a retraction. It's more complete. For some people even might be easier than the previous exercise. That's why you can try them both.

Step 1. Take protracted Maltese position - grip twice the shoulder's width or more with feet on the ground, closely next to each other. Like on the first picture from **Figure 5.10**. Here the tension has to be equal between all the muscles, same as usual when you do Maltese. You must feel the chest raised as higher as possible. You may try to stretch your back upwards as well, that will support the protraction, it's a personal choice.

Step 2. Here we go lower with chest, by increasing a bit the lean level forward. While you are going lower – start to inhale. You have to feel how you are unable to activate your trapezoid as usual, because of the

incorrect stance you are getting in. Here you have to rely mostly on your grip and lower back to keep you standing, also use the ankle of your feet to assist by absorbing the bodyweight backward. When you feel your chest relaxed – hold for 2 seconds. Second picture from **Figure 5.10**.

Step 3. From relaxed retracted position start to push the chest back to the highest point, if it's possible try even a bit higher, compared to main position. While you are pushing the chest higher – start to exhale and use the ankle of your feet to assist by pushing your bodyweight higher. When you reach the top position don't stop the push, keep it and hold in that position for 2 seconds. Like on 3rd picture from **Figure 5.10**.

MALTESE SIMULATION PUSH IN STANDING POSITION



Figure 5.11 – Maltese simulation push in standing position

For this one you will need an average bar in order to use it's bases and that's the first preparational exercise for the actual resistance of Maltese push (it can be easily done on the door frame as well, if you are training at home). Here we use mainly the toes apply force forward and like this to creating a need of resistance from the upper body to counter it (the

same one, which we need to hold Maltese). It's supposed to be executed by the following way:

- Step 1.** Take one foot distance from the bases line and place your hands for neutral grip. Let the shoulders in front of the chest (the 1st picture from **Figure 5.11**).
- Step 2.** Slowly start to push with the toes of your feet up and forward.
- Step 3.** Keep the shoulders protracted and depressed (in front and down), while you are pushing and chest as high as you can. Flex the trapezoid by slightly extending your neck up and forward. Keep the bicep flexed all the time (the 2nd picture from **Figure 5.11**).

IMPORTANT: Increase the tension slowly when you are going for this push. The purpose of it is to feel it max close to the actual move. Your max activation should be around 80%.

I would recommend 2 sets x 15 seconds of hold.

MALTESE LEANS



Figure 5.12 – Maltese leans

The last, but not the last as importance – Maltese leans. One of the best exercises as Maltese basics is also one of the best for warm up. The right execution of Maltese leans is the key to successful and quick progress, towards the dream of achieving this powerful skill. The execution has to be done in the following way:

- Step 1.** Get ready for neutral/protracted Maltese position on the ground - grip twice the shoulder's width or more with feet. Be sure your fingers are looking aside from your body, not towards your legs. We are looking at the first picture from **Figure 5.12**.
- Step 2.** Lean forward with push from the fingertips on the ground and slightly extend the neck up and forward. Keep the distance between the ears and the shoulders.
- Step 3.** When you reach leaned Maltese position with legs on the ground like on the second picture from **Figure 5.12**, be sure you are feeling the trapezoid and you are extra flexing the biceps. Hold in this position for 2-3 seconds, while you are keeping the chest push as high as possible, you can stretch your back higher if you want for more scapular support (I decided not to do it on the picture).
- Step 4.** Bring the lean back to main position by pushing up and backward with your arms. **Don't bring the lean back from your lower back.** It's wrong to rely a lot on it for the pull back. Keep pushing the chest while you are pushing backward to main position. Important detail is to don't bend your legs even for a second. **Keep the elbows locked all the time. Don't bent the arms just to go lower.** Pay attention of the lower back position right at the end – 3rd picture from **Figure 5.12**.

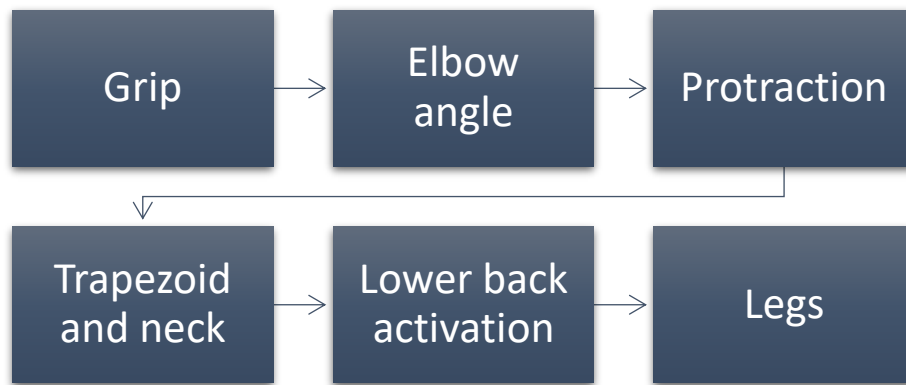
6. How are we opposing to our strength?

There are some factors which may affect your progress. Some athletes will need years to understand and locate them. Here we are going throughout all of them:

1. Technical details
2. How often we must train for Maltese
3. How often we must not train for Maltese
4. Not fully recovered from passed injuries

6.1 Technical details

The technical mistakes will be described in the following order:



GRIP

Fundamental detail when we are working for any static element is to make the difference between **grip positioning before the lean** and **grip positioning after the lean**. That makes huge difference, which is impossible to not being felt.

Let's take for example floor Maltese:

First – a lot of people are starting to lean forward while their fingers are already looking at the direction of their feet (final grip position). That will make things kind of tough from the very beginning. Why? Because like that there isn't any counter stabilization from other direction. But what if we start with laid hands, orientated aside from your body? The answer is – could be half easier. When you start your Maltese lean, if you push with your fingertips (**which you have to do, that's the right technique**) in the process of lean, your palms and fingers will rotate towards your feet's direction automatically. Like that your stability is far more and there is better control.

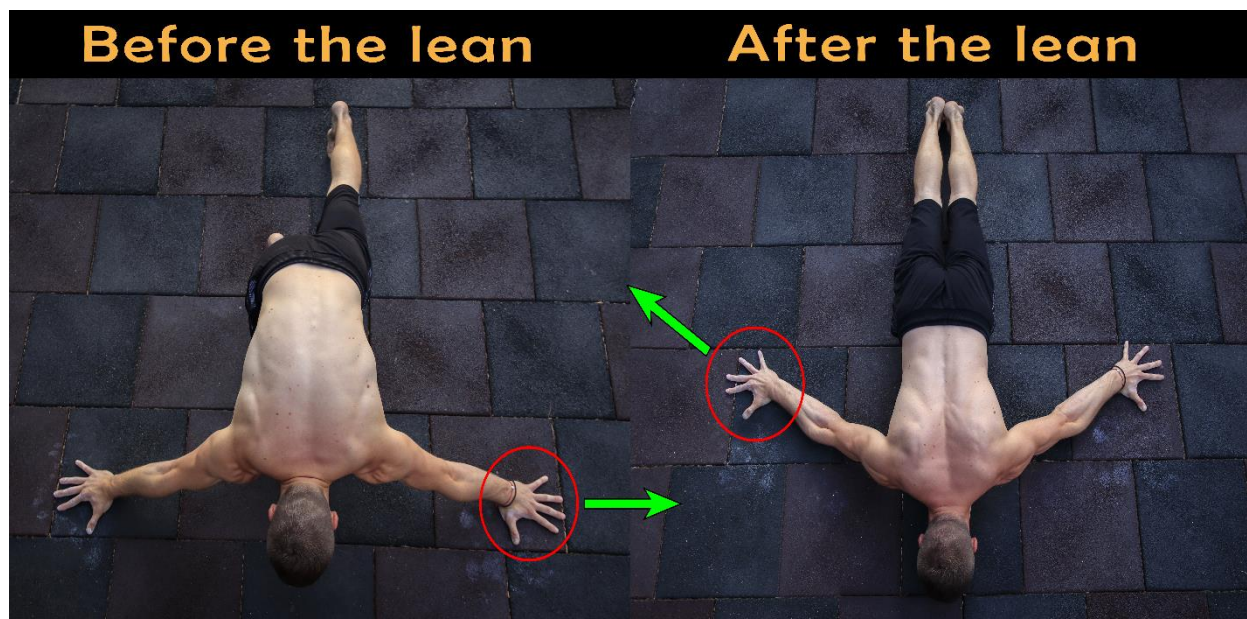


Figure 6.1 – Grip with fingers position before and after the lean

Second – choose wise your palm position for basics and attempts. Here you can see how:

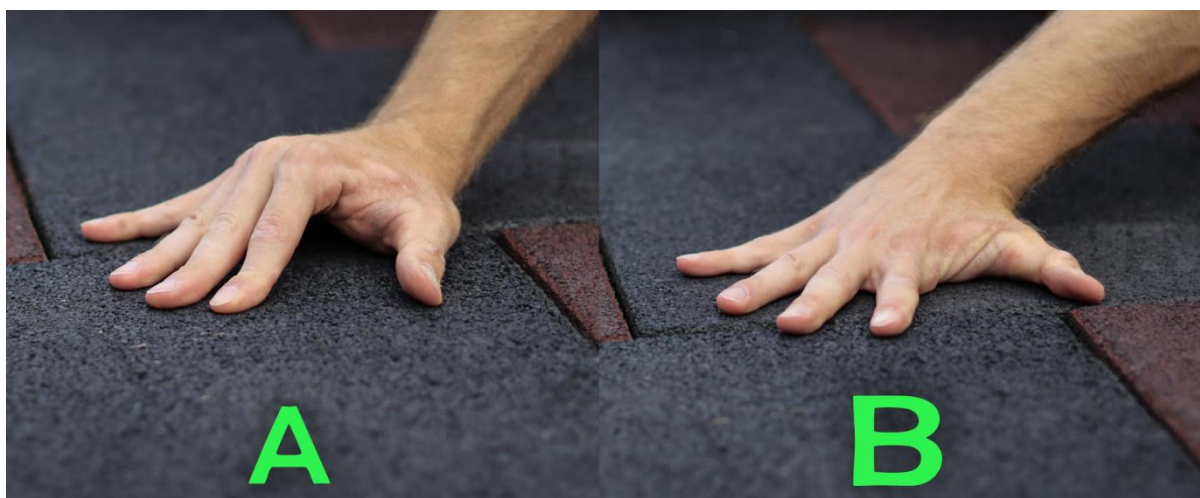


Figure 6.2 – Palm positions for Maltese

When it's okay to use case A: When you are just getting started with Maltese on floor and the elbows are still not that reliable, when you feel discomfort or pain there. That initially activates more the bicep and the forearm if you are not thinking more about it and takes away some from the elbow's tension. That makes attempts and basics way easier.

When it's okay to use case B: When you get better feeling about your elbows and when you want some challenging basics or attempts to see how finished your muscle link for Maltese is. Like that you are putting the entire palm laid and the arm length appears to feel longer during the practice, which is an option if you want to try hard. I recommend it for Maltese basics, when your elbows are ready to withstand the tension.

Third – no matter what's the case be sure to rely on your thumbs when you do Maltese leans on floor. If your palm position is strictly fixed and not liquid, while you are keeping the pressure to maintain the form of your palm and pressing your thumb in front that will create a great support, which if you haven't tried – it's a game changer!

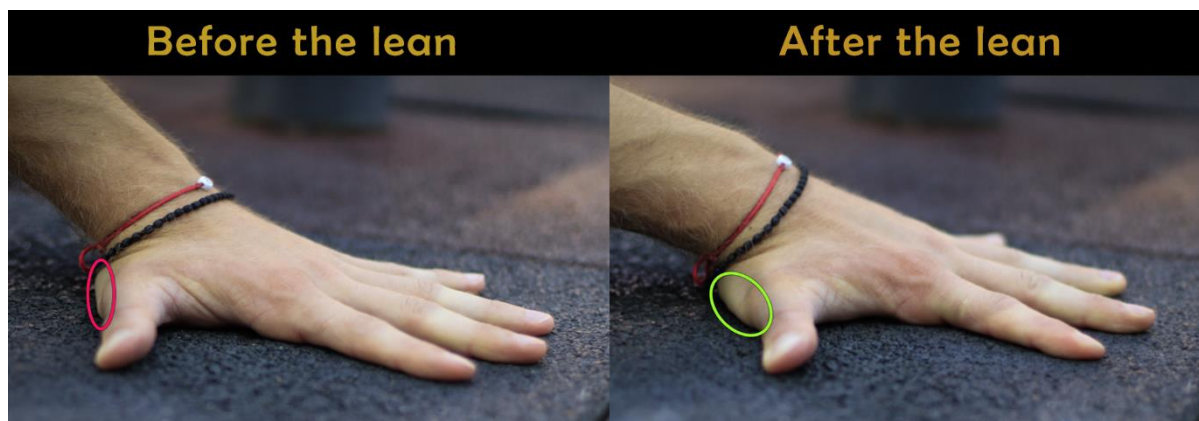


Figure 6.3 – Floor grip thumb pressure change

That will be enough for floor Maltese. Let me show the example with the other main and final position of the grip:



Figure 6.4 - Vertical poles – main and final position

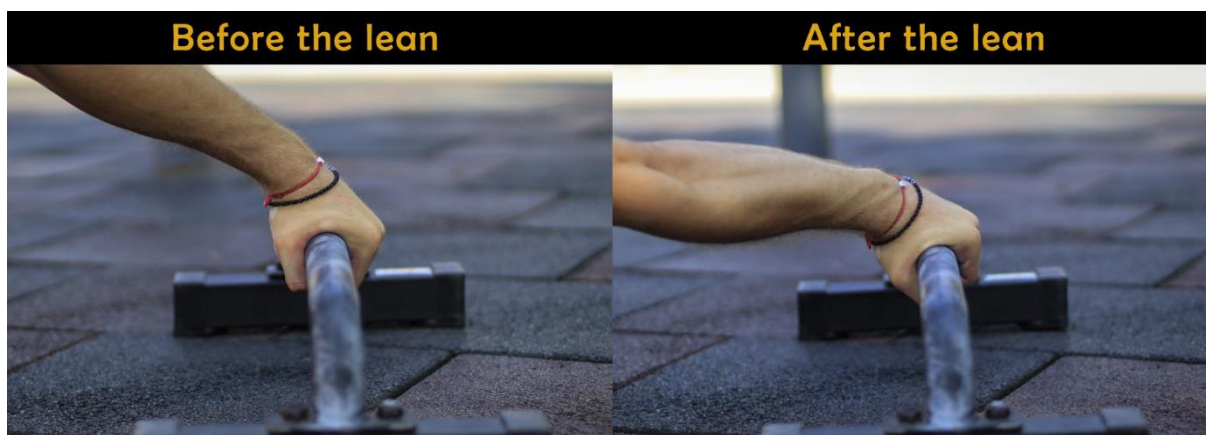


Figure 6.5 – Neutral grip on parallel bars – main and final position



Figure 6.6 – Pronated bar grip – main and final position



Figure 6.7 – Supinated bar grip– main and final position

If you try to notice the common in all the grips – I try to maintain straight wrist line after the lean.

ELBOW ANGLE

Keep bicep and shoulder in balanced proportions of activation. If you rotate shoulders too much in front – the bicep activation might be lost and you will have to put extra bicep activation later. If you let the bicep to look too much forward, then you are placing too much tension upon him and it might be dangerous.



Figure 6.8 – A – too much activated bicep/ B – too much rotated shoulder

As we talked above – keep the 100% activation separated between the shoulder (50%) and the bicep (50%). Flex them equally, while your arms are at Maltese stance, the result is correct position of the elbow's angle:



Figure 6.9 – Balanced activation between bicep and shoulder

There is 50% reduction of bicep injury for some athletes already if you are a beginner into the Maltese basis.

PROTRACTION OR NEUTRAL SCAPULA?

Keeping the chest as high as possible will improve your form and control a lot. For this purpose we have to keep the shoulders in front of the chest and to add an extra tension from ourselves, while we are pushing.

Protraction doesn't require a lot of lower back activation upward (anterior pelvic tilt). And can be combined with neutral position or activated downward (posterior pelvic tilt).



Figure 6.10 – Hollow form

Hollow form as form can be described like – chest/back up – lower back down – legs up. This form controls the lean level higher and it's suitable for longer combinations.

It is true that protraction improves the form. For that there isn't any doubt. But for those ones who would like their Maltese to look lower (for example on the ground) – there's an option to lower a bit more to neutral scapula position. That will make you look like millimeters from the ground.



Figure 6.11 – Balanced form Maltese – “straight line”

The desire for low Maltese may lead you to pull the chest lower, which changes the posture to retraction. Be careful and observe your attempts, before to end with retracted form. As you can see it even breaks the line and you may look a bit with “banana” form.



Figure 6.12 – Retracted Maltese

After a long hold for you and when the muscle fatigue hits – you may retract anyway. Know for yourself when is the best moment to release the Maltese hold. Too much retraction isn't healthy.

TRAPEZOID AND NECK

To make it easier will put 4 cases of different neck activation and will analyze all of them before to look at the right neck/trapezoid detail.

Case A: The tension is too high, but you want to try to go low as much as you can, so you decide to push with your neck as much as you can downward.

Consequences: The feeling is like you are on the edge between protraction and neutral form, sometimes if your posture control is not really mastered – close to reach retraction. The neck is pulling you down, which makes Maltese way harder, let say 20% more. That's it because the neck muscles are not playing the role of a counter force. That means they are not opposing anyhow to the lean. Logically you are falling easier.

More details for that case: Ears are far from the shoulder, which means there is a shoulder's depression. That's a good sign, however the direction of the neck pull is the problem.

Case B: The tension is too high so you decide to pull the lean back as much as you can, but you don't know exactly how so you shrug the neck between the shoulders.

Consequences: The feeling is like you are pushing the shoulders closer to their neck. That's completely wrong because if we go back for what we were saying earlier – the trapezoid has the highest percentage of activation, compared to the other muscle groups (20%). By pushing our shoulders closer to neck and looking downward we are telling him – “Yo, you won't take part in this movement, you are needless.” and like that we are also rejecting approximately 30% of our strength. We don't want to do that.

More details for that case: Ears are close to the shoulder, which creates a lack of shoulder's depression. The neck is trying to pull the lean back, there's an attempt to counter the lean, however it's not enough.

Here you can see the cases we were talking about:



Figure 6.13 – Case A – neck pulling downward / Case B – shoulder's elevation

Let's see another case, when the neck is pulling too much and the depression is available.

Case C: The tension is less during the lean/attempt, because both details are fulfilled. The focus is on the head – why it's elevated that high?

Consequences: The feeling is like you are pushing the shoulders closer to their neck. The head position feels uncomfortable. You are protracting, but somehow you feel like you are so close to lose it and to retract at any moment. The reason is the link between the head and the chest. The link is your neck. The more your head is pulling up and back – the more your chest will go down.

More details for that case: Ears are far from the shoulder, which means there is a shoulder's depression. That's a good sign, however the neck pull is too much – that's the problem. As you can see it's similar to case A.

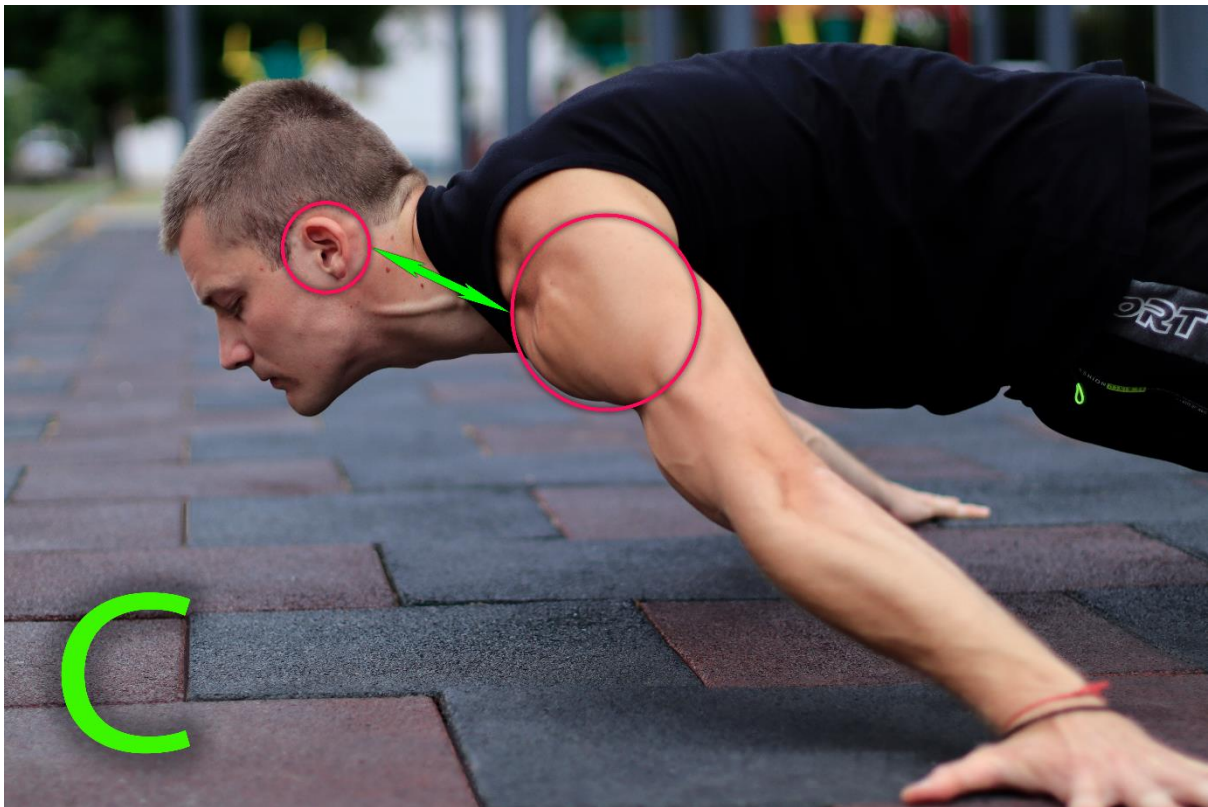


Figure 6.14 – Case C – neck overactivation

Case D – the correct one: You decide to find the right balance between direction of the neck pull, how much to pull with your head, to depress the shoulders and to keep the ears-shoulders distance.

Consequences: Balanced approach feels way better.

*More details for that case: Ears are far from the shoulder, which means there is a shoulder's depression. The head isn't pulling too high. If you try to film your lean/attempt you may notice your ears and shoulders aligned (that's why the circles on **Figure 5.** are green). The head position isn't uncomfortable. The distance ears-shoulders is fulfilled.*

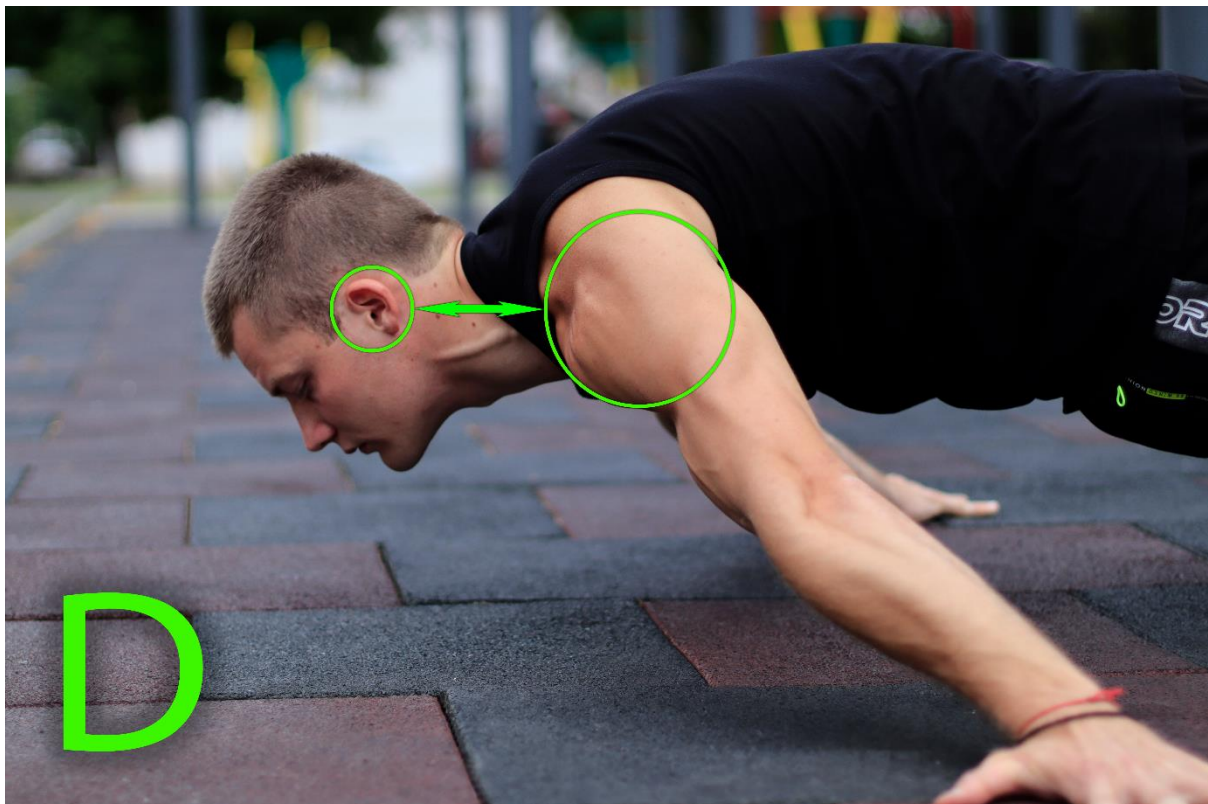


Figure 6.15 – balanced protraction and neck activation

The exit words from all of these cases are – too less is not enough, too much may have consequences, you have to find the right balance.

LOWER BACK ACTIVATION AND ATP OVERACTIVATION CASE

Before to step in the lower back activation there's a figure which you have to take a look at. It's showing different pelvis positions which are applying for lower back form of the Maltese/Planche as well.

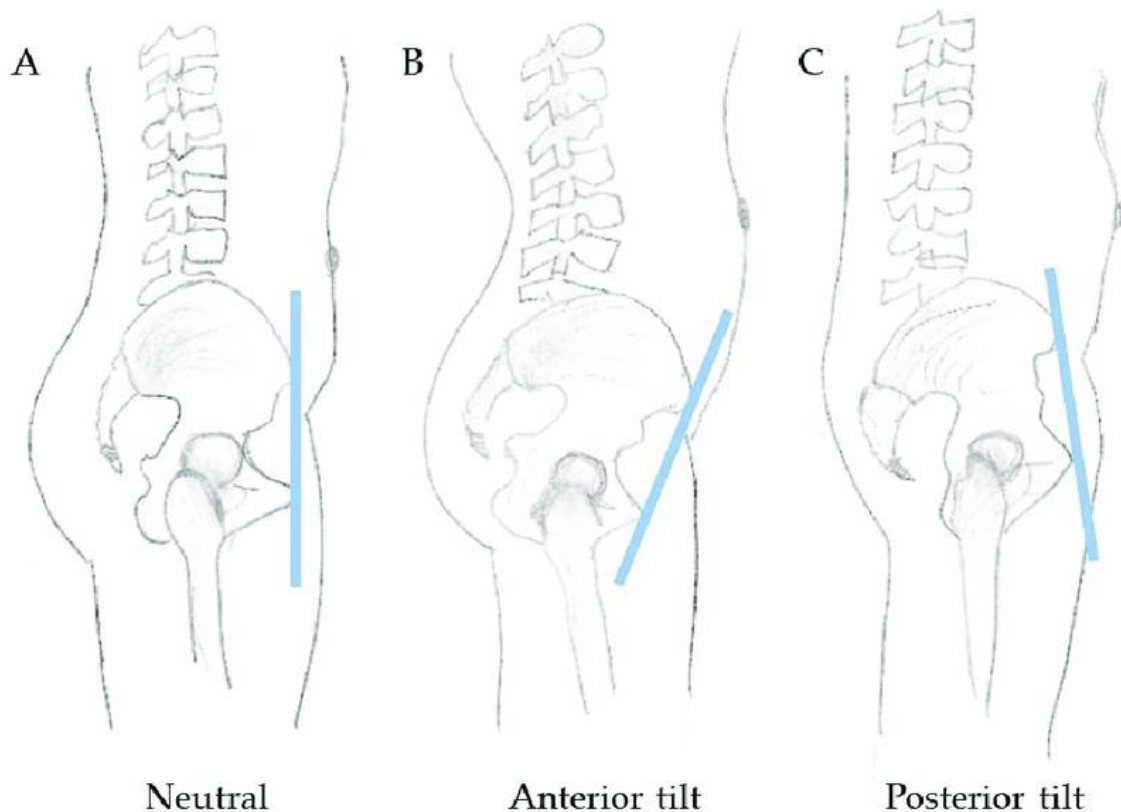


Figure 6.16 – Neutral pelvic tilt - Anterior pelvic tilt - Posterior pelvic tilt

Depending from what kind of form you want to perform – balanced straight line or hollow form; there's quite a difference for how the lower back is supposed to be felt.

Straight line form

Straight line activation requires balanced approach between posterior and anterior pelvic tilt. I prefer this kind of form.

For that kind of form it's recommendable to use the A case from **Figure 6.16**. Some people would like to mix it between neutral and posterior more, for everyone would be different. The thing I'm trying to say about this type of form is – try to find your balance. This detail is taking a lot of time to be fixed. Record all your attempts even if you delete them afterwards, just take a look and see what has to be fixed in the next attempts.



Figure 6.17 – Balanced lower back approach between PPT and APT

If you don't want to break the straight line with too much posterior pelvic tilt – try to focus on posterior pelvic tilt just enough to counter the “book” form case:

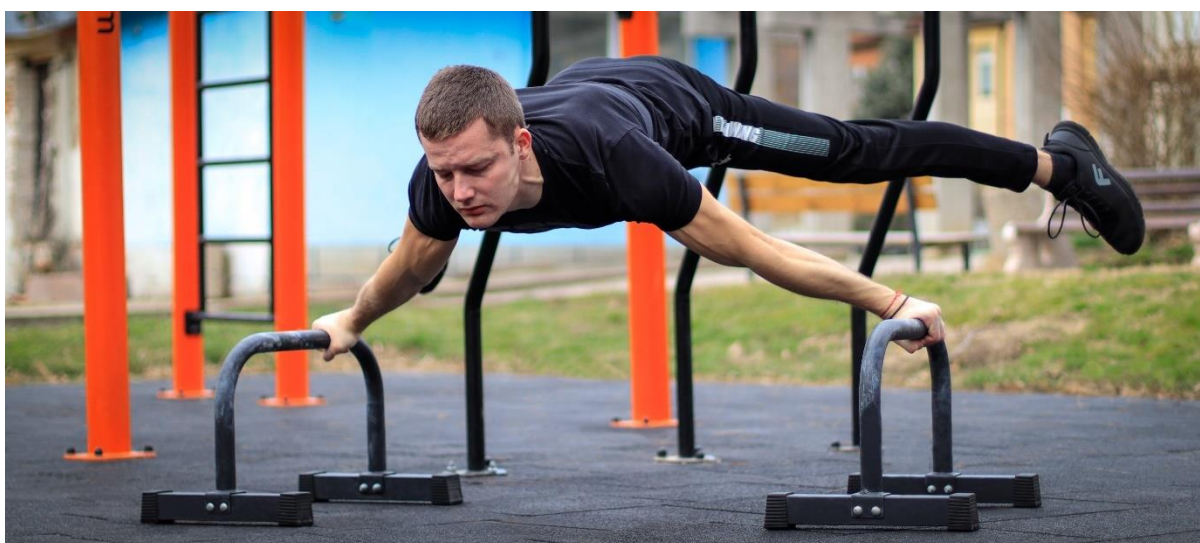


Figure 6.18 – “Book” form, caused by excessive anterior pelvic tilt activation

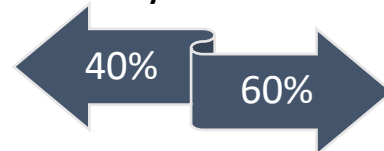
The Maltese “book” form is anterior pelvic tilt overactivation. During the hold of this form, as you can see – the lower back is arching and the glutes are going way above the line we are striving for. The anterior pelvic tilt overactivation also makes the lats in such a shape, when you squeeze the protraction is getting lost – with other words the chest is getting in front of the shoulders. The lats are strong and large muscles and if they don't work in your favor – you can easily stuck with protraction issues. We are switching the protraction with retraction as a final result. You see - it's like a chain link.

The other case is to apply too much posterior pelvic tilt as activation – with neutral scapula posture – it will look more like banana form. As result even if you aim to keep neutral position it will be a retraction.



Figure 6.19 – Posterior pelvic tilt with retraction/neutral form

If you choose straight line I would recommend you – no matter if it's Maltese or Planche. When you are doing basics as leans, leaned push ups, even your current tuck progression attempts – keep your lower back activated **nearly 40 – 60%**.



Hollow Maltese form



Figure 6.20 – Posterior pelvic tilt + protraction

With that scapular posture more suitable is to apply only posterior pelvic tilt, without to balance between ppt and apt. It's up to you how would you like to choose your hollow form to look like. From that also depends and how much you are going to push your hips downwards.

LEGS

Another mistake is to limit your body activation, while you are performing Maltese. When we are saying Maltese/planche affects only the upper body muscles, big part of the street workout community is understanding that like – isolate your upper body from your lower body, lower body doesn't take part in that movement, your focus on the movement will be better. Yes, directly it doesn't take any of the supporting roles as the other muscles from the upper body for the hold, but if you are not flexing your legs, glutes and spine in sync your Maltese/planche form will look kind of “broken”, especially in straddle form:



Figure 6.21 – Straddle Maltese with relaxed legs

Here's an example if you miss the legs activation for full Maltese form:



Figure 6.22 – Full Maltese with relaxed legs

Flex your legs in such a way, so to continue the upper body shape and to remove this angle between your hips and stomach. You have to squeeze with the legs in the same way like you are squeezing with your lower back. It has to be felt as one unit. Then the result will look in the right way:



Figure 6.23 – Straddle Maltese with flexed legs



Figure 6.24 – Full Maltese with flexed legs

6.2 How often to train Maltese?

The suitable number of workouts per week for anyone is different.

If you are a beginner in certain element – the recommended number of workouts **must not be** more than 2-3 per week. In the first months your body needs to adapt to the stress.

If you already have some time into Maltese workouts and got used a little bit more to the high tension – I would recommend to keep the same amount of workout per week, just the tension has to be increased, of course. Once you are used – add more volume in your workouts to be able later – to endure on longer workout sessions, when you want to include more attempts.

I would recommend only for advanced athletes to keep up to 4 workouts per week, who have some serious intension of improving their Maltese skills on another level. Even then – that's under question. Max 3 workouts per week are the optimum if you want to advance forward and to stay safe from injuries.

TENSION IN THE WORKOUTS

The last, but not with less meaning tip – when you are doing leans simulate like you are doing a real Maltese and imagine how you are pushing for it, using all of these tips we were talking until now. Always extra flex your muscles even more than the required tension to hold the Maltese basics, like that your body will become stronger in short terms of time to endure Maltese's load. **It's a good tip, but don't overdo it in every workout!** Do it only when you feel yourself fresh and you have taken enough rest from the previous workouts.

This tip helped me pretty much, because my mindset was "It's better to be tough during the basics, instead during the holds".

6.3 How often not to train Maltese?

As we talked above the optimum workout per week is 2-3 per week average for anyone who wants to learn how to fly. But let's talk what would happen if we don't follow these numbers.

Let's imagine you haven't been serious in your Maltese workouts until now and you skip one week for example - that's a precondition your muscle memory to lose the effect of

much work, done until now. It's okay to be taken one week if you need to deload, but not and when there's not a need for it. It's a step back.

Let present it in this way – more than 2 days skip and the body is starting to forget. You are losing the momentum of your progression. You will recover already and instead to progress straight after your recovery is completed – you will move back with some steps in your progress, because the required muscle stress will be missing. The body needs to be challenged at the right time, instead of listening to random tips how often – listen to your body.

Another scenario: You are training every single day, whenever you have the motivation and you want to fully use it. Sometimes you even train twice per day. I know how it sounds, but many can agree there are such a people, because they want progress no matter want and they don't listen to their body. The effect from that is the following – your body is so oversaturated with loading. In the first days the body is feeling soreness, no matter what you do, but you think it's the best you can do for yourself. Weeks later with such a regiment of workouts – you don't feel any pain. It's gone, so it's your progress.

The body needs time. It's annoying, but it needs time. Good things take time. If you are not ready to sacrifice from your time in order to recover. Better don't start at all. You will pass through a lot of pain and injuries. That was the way how I learnt. I don't recommend it, because now it would be different. **Take care of your health!**

6.4 Injuries from the past

The desire to go back into your workout pace is awesome. Keeping your health however is more important. If you have started again and you feel any kind of pain somewhere in bicep, shoulders, elbows, wrists and so on and it is not a pain from joint/bone or it specifically a muscle pain – I would advice you to do a routine with preparation exercises. If the pain is small and you think it's going to pass – keep going and see how your body is responding. Think about your current technique – the problem could be there also, it's not necessary to visit a doctor immediately.

If the pain is so hard to stand and it keeps going no matter what you do from the said things above – do your research who is the best sport injuries doctor for your case and make an appointment with him about your injury. Our sport is dangerous enough to take unnecessary risks, before to be ready in advance.

7. Types of workouts

Type of workout	Definition	Loading
<i>Preparational</i>	That's usually the starting point for anyone. This kind of workouts are more suitable when there are no competitions or sport-specific work has been limited. With other words – everyone has to start with this kind of routines when he's stepping back into the workout or when there was something missing in terms of technique. The main goal of these trainings is to develop basic level of conditioning in order to increase the athlete's ability to tolerate more intensive training.	Up to 40%
<i>Progressive</i>	The types of workouts which we usually keep up with after the preparational workouts. They are suitable for the days when we feel fresh and recovered. It's important not every workout during the week to be from that type. You will oversaturate your body with stress.	70% – 100%
<i>Maintaining</i>	This kind of workout fits for the days when you don't feel truly fresh and recovered, but more exhausted and like it's not your day. In days with such a workout you have to keep pace with half of your capacity and nothing serious. Just light workout to keep the muscle memory.	40% – 60%

8. Physical and mental health

8.1 Physical health

With physical health we mean to avoid pain, injuries and unnecessary soreness. Here I'm going to discuss the main 2 problems people are facing during the Maltese workouts. Sometimes there's a forearm pain/wrist pain, sometimes it's the elbows, but mainly people face the problem with the elbows.

Let start first with the pain which sometimes we think is an injury. There comes the question about the outer part of the forearm first. Our body isn't supposed to be subjected on such a stress in the upper body area. If we say that – our beginning is link with the perfect pain, as it should be – the muscles won't be pleased at exactly that period. About pain in the outer part of the forearm – you may mistake it with a bone pain, that's how it feels like. That's caused by exercising high level tension gripping from these 3 fingers – middle, unnamed and pinkie. This case appears when you practice Maltese on parallelles mainly.

Here it's shown the reason of your uncomfortable pain there, in the forearm.

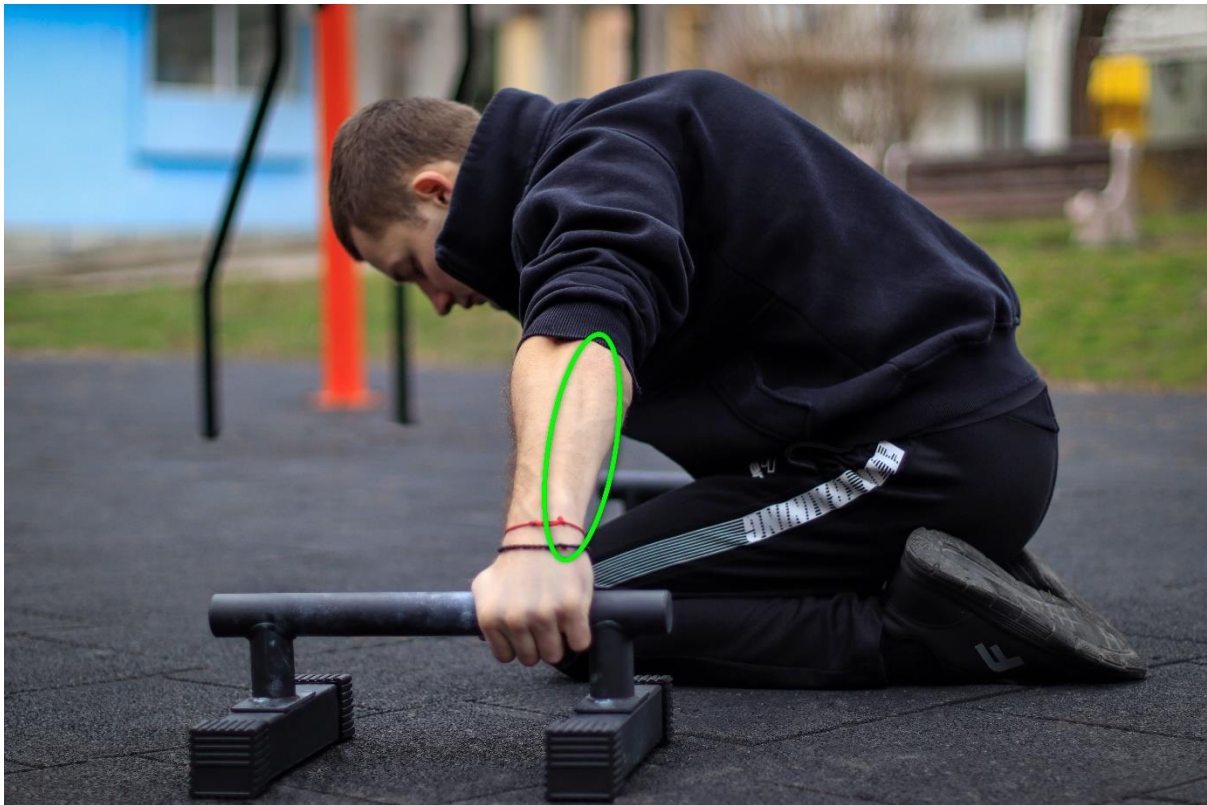


Figure 8.1 – Painful area after Planche/Maltese attempts or basics

We can avoid it by follow these steps after the Maltese attempts/painful Maltese basics:

1. When you end the exercise – keep pushing as you were doing during the hold/basics.
2. Start to release your fingers one by one while you are still pushing the parallellette.
3. When you release all of your finger's grip – start to release the palm push on the parallellette as well.
4. Move away your hand from the parallellette.

These simple steps are tested by many people and they are approved as helpful.

ELBOW PAIN

Another useful subject is how to avoid pain in the elbows. Many athletes are using elbow sleeves. That may help if the pain is truly not going away, no matter what are you doing and if it remains since long period of time.

The solution might appear to be a technical fix. Here comes the role of the bicep. By keeping it flexed, even at a fully locked elbow joint – the pain will be reduced significantly. The support from the bicep tendons and the muscle tissue are great relief for the elbow joint. Give it a try in your next Maltese workout and try to feel the difference.

If you have overactivated your bicep in this way until now, it may cause another pain in the bicep. Like overstretch and a lot of soreness.

IMPORTANT: Don't overdo the support from the bicep. The ratio shoulder/bicep activation has to be equal – 50/50! Overdone activation of the bicep may cause a bicep injury, which you have to truly avoid!

The additional bicep activation has to change your elbow angle, so don't be surprised if that happens – it is correct. You have to think like you are controlling every single Maltese attempt with the bicep.

8.2 Mental health

Mindset is the next keyframe. Remember what we talked from the very start – *“For Maltese can be said: It's a symbol of strength in the pushing static skills.”*, so don't expect to be easy in any case. It could be everything, but not and easy! Keep that in mind, when you go for it.



PREPARATION FOR MALTESE PROGRESS

People regularly are asking – *“How many seconds full planche hold I need before to start with Maltese?”*. The answer usually from many athletes is to be somewhere near at 7 – 10 seconds of clean form full planche. They are correct and not in the same time. I will tell you why: As difficulty Maltese is way above the regular planche and it requires it's time and efforts, however for many people will take more to master Maltese. In case to keep your motivation and determination higher is recommendable to pass through full planche first, as they say. If you consider yourself as person, who often has a lack of motivation and you are getting upset after some days/weeks of unsuccessful attempts – I recommend you to pass through full planche first to keep your mindset healthy.

If you are from the kind of people who would take the bold decision to master both the full planche and Maltese in the same time – prepare yourself with tons of patience and dedication, because you have to think a lot on what you are doing. You have to analyze each detail of your moves, because the chest activation and the bicep extension are different for both of the elements. The body needs the time to adapt to everything you exercise.

My personal experience is the following: I started with both of them in the same time. I didn't know how to rest, I didn't know anything about the details I told you, the year was 2014 there was nothing as knowledge available in the web, as it is right now. I had to do many mistakes with both of the elements. It took me 3 months to master straddle planche and one more month to switch to full planche. On the 7th month of my planche journey I

was able to resist and to hold for 2 seconds the straddle Maltese with locked elbows. Months later my Maltese was more controlled than my full planche. That boosted way more my confidence about goals and everything I wished to achieve. After that for 15 years old boy – there was nothing impossible, but to get there wasn't easy. In the process of unconsciously achieving the Maltese I was mad at this element more than you can even imagine. Everything I did was feeling meaningless, I was just falling over and over again, until I did it.

Conclusions of everything we said until now in this part: The approach to your Maltese progress has to be methodical, followed by patience. There's time for everything. There's time to learn everything you would like to know.

IN THE PROCESS OF WORK

Pay close attention on details. Most of the cases a lot of people are doing one kind of details during their basics and completely opposite details when they go for attempts.

The decision is to look yourself in the mirror, or simply to record yourself. That will help a lot to find your mistakes and to improve all the weak points. Do it until your attempts look exactly as your basics in terms of activation. **But until you are not ready with the correct activation during your basics – it's absolutely no recommended to train with attempts, except to test the progress with the tuck progression.**

AFTER THE PROCESS OF WORK

Let's imagine you have mastered Maltese – one of the hardest static elements and you are proud of yourself. So proud you are even putting a standard to others, who can some impressive elements, but not and Maltese. In your mind you are judging the person with who you are comparing just by that who can do harder skill.

Some mistakes in this scenario:

1st: Never compare yourself with anyone else, if you are not going to face him on competition.

2nd: One element should never decide an outcome of a calisthenics battle/set. There are plenty of elements. It's harder to maintain many other elements, instead of one hard element. The judges know that, that's why there is a point system.

3rd: Don't skip other elements, because of a harder one. Later it will make you feel incomplete.

4th: Don't get full of yourself, just because you have mastered Maltese. That's the most important one. This mental mistake may lead to all the mistakes above.

9. Maltese workout ratio

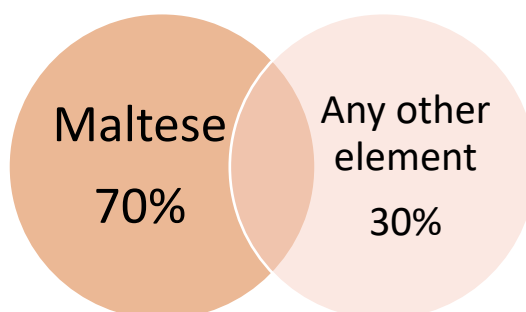
Street workout athletes are often wondering how to combine Maltese workouts with other elements.

MALTESE: BEGINNERS LEVEL

If you are a beginner in Maltese I would recommend you to don't mix it with anything else in one workout and after your most tough Maltese workout to give yourself at least one day rest in order the muscle memory to be built. Keep it up like that until you reach mastered 6 seconds of straddle Maltese with good form.

MALTESE: INTERMEDIATE LEVEL

If your case is mastered 6 seconds straddle Maltese and you are even going with unstable hold for full Maltese with imperfect shape – here's the loading ration per workout:



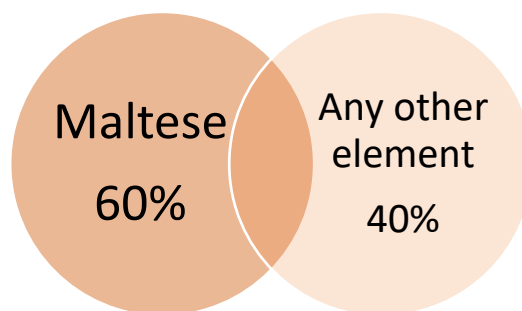
As you can see the overall workout has to be devoted for Maltese and the remaining efforts for maintenance of element you would like to not fall back. It might be: **planche** (hold/press/push – one of them), **front lever** (hold/press/pull – one of them), **handstand practice**.

I don't recommend at this state high level bicep activation. It may affect the integrity of the bicep, because as you know it's truly vulnerable to injuries. Example of high bicep activation might be caused by **rings practice** and **hefesto**. Avoid to mix your Maltese workouts with these activities.

MALTESE: ADVANCED LEVEL

As advanced level athletes we may consider people who have mastered full maltese for at least 6 seconds and are capable to perform different kind of Maltese variation, they may have even Maltese push up and press in their arsenal.

Because of the escalation of the level the loading ratio per workout might look like this:



The recommendations about how to mix our Maltese workout don't change, comparing to the intermediate level.

10. Maltese variations

We have finally reached my favorite part!

Maltese allows athletes to choose between many different variations. That's why we love it so much, of course if we don't count the fact - it's the most powerful looking static element.

The two most common Maltese variations are neutral grip (on parallettes) and on floor. Let's discuss them first.

NEUTRAL GRIP MALTESE ON PARALLETTES

Maltese on parallettes is recommended for any calisthenics athlete, who just steps in the Maltese game. The natural opportunity for better grip and stability, compared to the other variation makes it the most preferred one.



Figure 10.1 – Neutral grip Maltese

Specifics: The direction of squeezing is inward (wrist towards the body). The more you squeeze – the more you will feel the grip support into the engaged muscle groups, also easier to maintain a certain lean level.

MALTESE ON FLOOR

Truly beautiful and at first look simple variation. Let's look a bit deeper into it, what we should specifically look for:



Figure 10.2 – Maltese on floor

For many athletes that's truly hard variation, because there are a few details, which you have to catch before to start with this variation.

Specifics: We already mention in the part of technical details about the [grip](#) - how the hand has to be positioned before to lean forward. That's all which you need to know. After fixing this important detail you will catch everything else with the help of the remaining details which we were talking about in this book already.

MALTESE ON FINGERS

Probably that's the most beautiful variation for a lot of street workout athletes, which may let you out of breath if you see it with perfect form for first time live.



Figure 10.3 – Maltese on fingers

Specifics: Here the direction of the push, like for any other Maltese variation is towards the body. The difference is you have to implement it with your fingers, instead with your palm/grip. Many athletes can mistake it by pushing aside from the body and they might feel their elbow pain stronger than ever, if there's any.

Most of the bodyweight is falling on the thumb, because by default it's the strongest finger and in the same time closest finger to the body, during the hold of the variation.

Your feeling for fingertips Maltese will be improved if you keep your palm higher and fingers closer to each other, not close to be lain on the floor. That's the case if your thumbs are weak, just like mine. For me it's easier like that.

The other case – if you have confidence in your thumb's strength you may try with more spread fingers. Everything is individual – I'm just showing the cases.

MALTESE ON WRISTS

This kind of Maltese is kind of cheat, compared to the regular Maltese of floor.



Figure 10.4 – Maltese on wrists

Specifics: Usually the hand is clenches into a fist, for better forearm activation in order to keep Maltese stabler. The pressure point appears to be the wrist, instead of your palm. That's like your arm is getting shorter, you have more resistance for the lean and it feels more stable. It's more squeezing based variation.

The variation will look better if you apply more posterior pelvic tilt, compared to usual and your focus is to be less leaned, with more protraction.

MALTESE ON INVERTED WRISTS

This kind of Maltese has 2 ways in which can be done. One of them is making the variation easier, the other one – harder. The easier one is when you let half of your wrist laid on the ground, pushing to keep your lean level and resistance. The harder one is to let the whole wrist to lay on the ground.

Specifics for half-inverted wrist: Here you have to place the inner part of your wrist to lay on the floor. Definitely easier and gives athletes a higher possibility to control their Maltese form. The arm twist is less and when you apply extra bicep activation you may feel it like an easier variation of regular Maltese.



Figure 10.5 – Maltese on half inverted wrists

Specifics for full-inverted wrist: Here the things are more specific, because even the outer part of your wrist has to be laid, not only the inner part. The arm twist is what it makes it so hard, even if you actually are making your arm shorter, because of the grip. I don't recommend the often execution of this variation, because there's possibility to harm your shoulder.



Figure 10.6 – Maltese on fully inverted wrists

Important tip: While executing both of the variations you will feel control during the hold if you apply push from your fist towards the floor.

MALTESE ON SUPINATED FISTS

Truly powerful and dangerous variation if your wrists are not so mobile. I will tell you my way of doing that, because my wrists are that type.

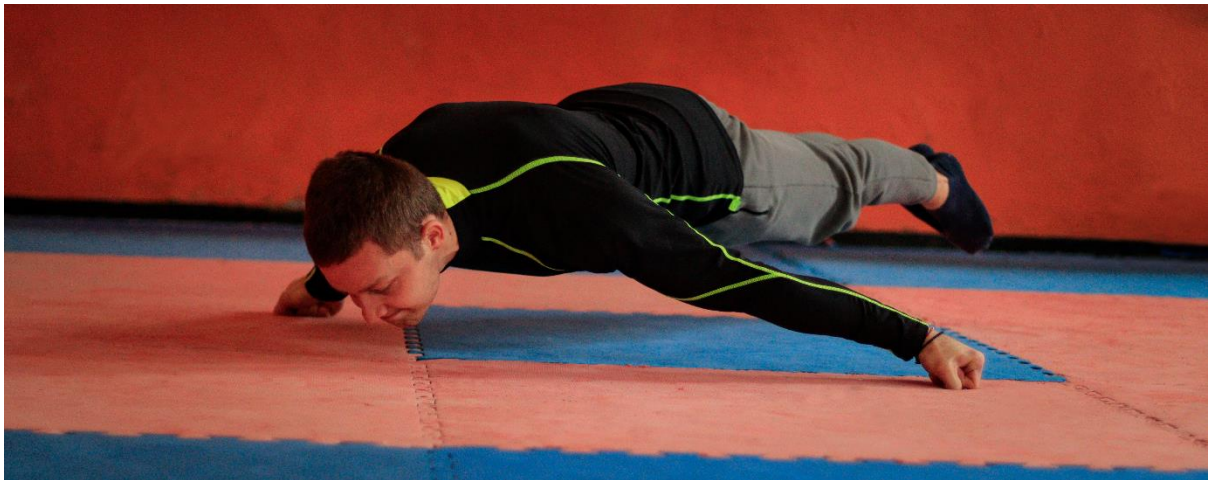


Figure 10.7 – Maltese on supinated fists

Specifics: Don't be ready with your fist in advance! Let your bodyweight onto the knuckles of pinkies and unnamed fingers.

For some people with mobile wrist it may look like Maltese on rings as a shape of the wrists.

MALTESE ON PRONATED FISTS

That's different and rare variation, because it's tough to keep the grip during the hold without to fall after the first few seconds.

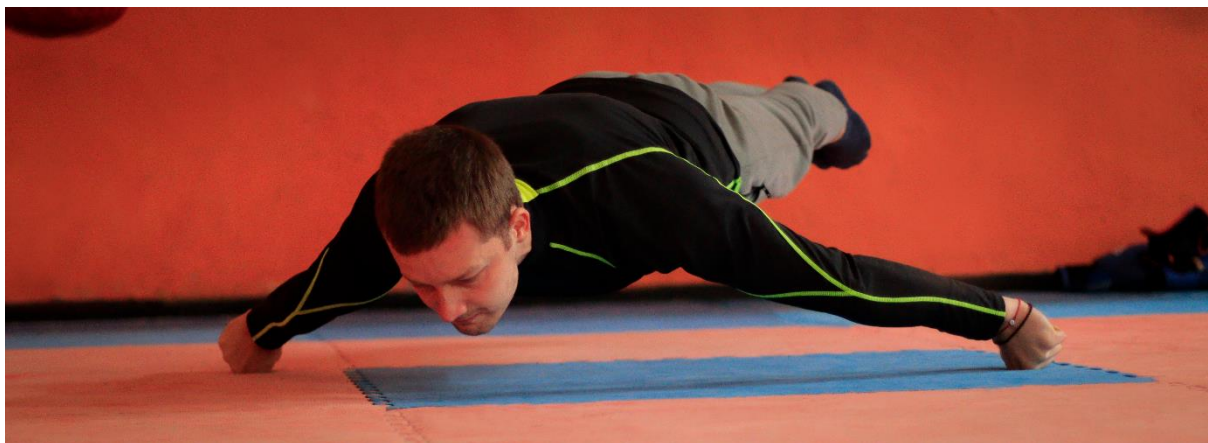


Figure 10.8 – Maltese on pronated fists

Specifics: Here it's allowed to be ready in advance with your fist and actually it's important to keep them stable and ready for the attempt. The bodyweight is falling on the knuckles of index and middle finger.

Try to do it on floor with not so liquid surface, not like me on the picture. You need some stability for that one.

MALTESE ON LAID FINGERS, HIGH WRIST

Majestical and specific variation. For some it may cause some pain issues in thumbs, for some not. If you are with sensitive thumbs, but with huge desire to achieve this variation – choose slow and steady approach, without jumping straight into it.



Figure 10.9 – Maltese on laid fingers/high wrists

Specifics: Place thumbs in laid position to look forward and fix the other fingers laid as well, but in supination. When you lean forward the 4 fingers (in supinated position) have to remain stable, without moving. Meanwhile thumbs have to push sideways to serve with extra stability and control. Here you have again different hands position before and after the lean.

MALTESE ON THUMBS

Here will be the easiest for me to explain, because – I don't have any experience with this variation, because by default my thumbs are extremely weak and no matter the strengthening exercises and the time I put in it – until now I haven't seen any result, anyway.

I'm writing about it, just to list it inside the book.



Figure 10.10 – Maltese on thumbs

MALTESE ON TWO FINGERS

Definitely one of the hardest Maltese variations in my opinion. Even if you are able to hold full planche on fingers with press afterwards – it doesn't guarantee you Maltese hold like that.



Figure 10.11 – Maltese on 2 fingers

Specifics: The most important thing, which you have to keep in mind is that there is HUGE importance to understand how you must keep your fingers. For me it has to be in this way:



Figure 10.12 – Fingers placement for Maltese on 2 fingers

As you can see on the picture you have to keep straight line between the fingers/back of the hand. With the lean forward the wrist angle will be switch, but even during the push you have to try keep that straight line. The other things are the same as like it applies for every Maltese variation.

Until there we discussed the main variation and probably all Maltese variations on ground.

Let's take a look at rings Maltese variations:

MALTESE ON RINGS

The main gymnastics Maltese variation as you already know. Rings require much more time spent in practice in order to catch the balance and stability here.

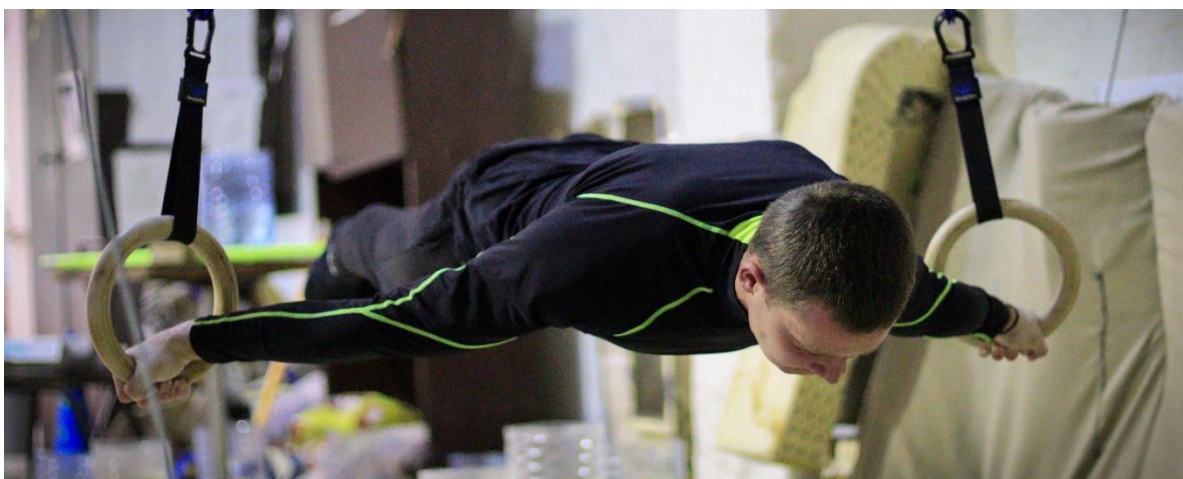


Figure 10.12 – Maltese on rings

Specifics: You have to imagine it more as pulling, instead of pushing element here. If you manage to control the rings to not shake and get wider – maintaining the protraction is all you need to nail it. But... It only sounds easy, that's tons of work.

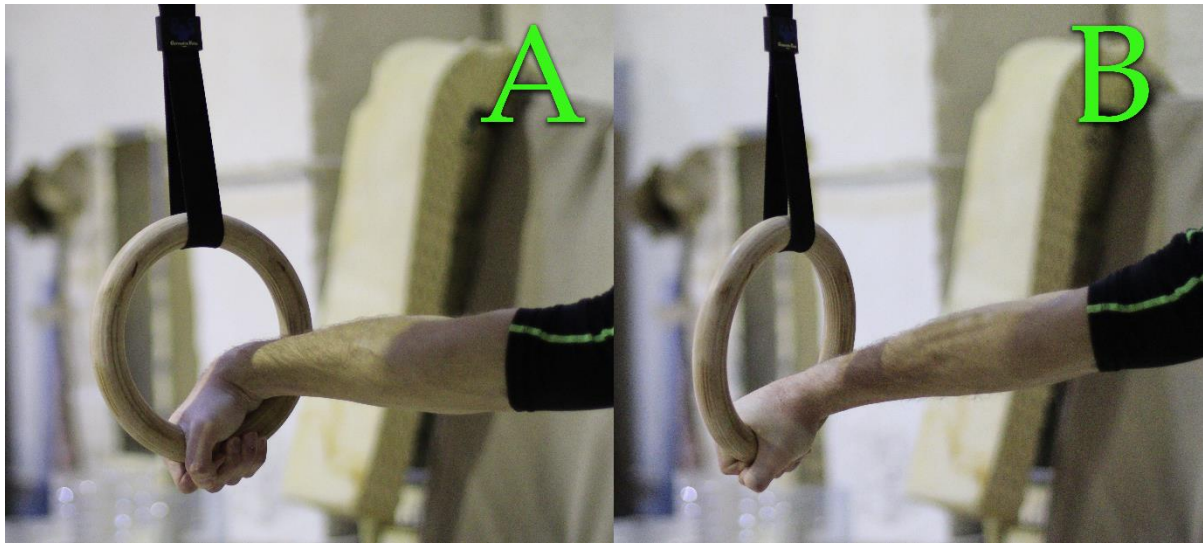


Figure 10.13 – Wrist position for Maltese on rings

On **Figure 10.13** case A shows rings grip if you have wrist mobility for false grip. Case B – if you lack the mobility for false grip on rings.

RING'S MALTESE ON INVERTED WRISTS

Another painful variation, based on wrist flexion. Rings allows only half-inverted wrist position, so it's all about the balance.

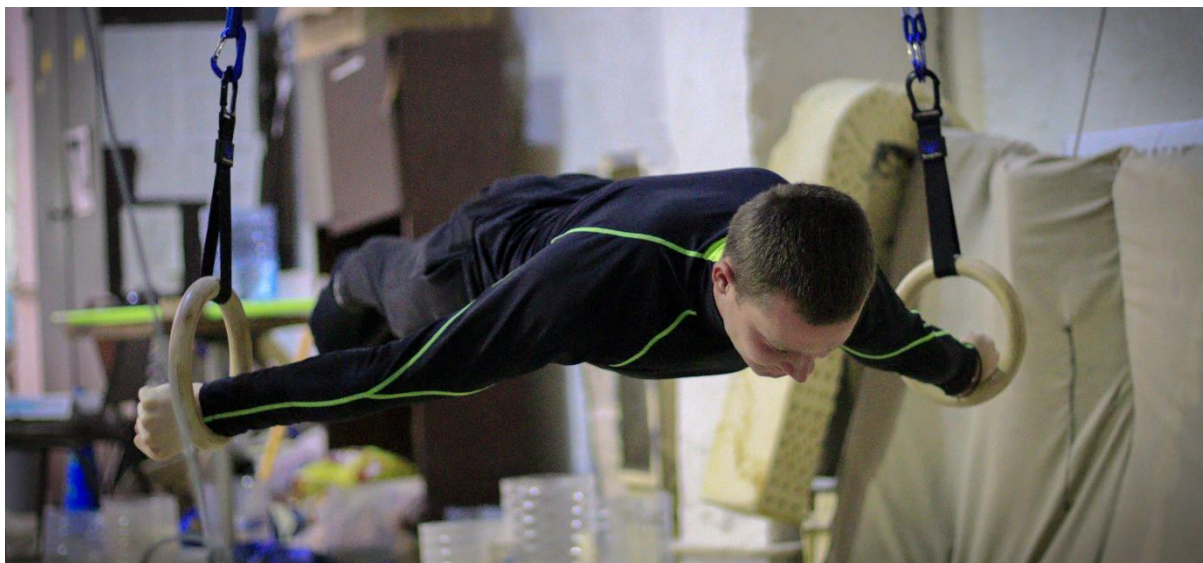


Figure 10.14 –Maltese on rings (inverted wrists)

Specifics: Rings has to meet 2 points of pressure from the wrist. That's why you have to use the fists as well. On **Figure 10.14** you can see how they are positioned slightly below the level of the rings. As difficulty level – the arm length feels like if you try false grip on rings, but with the required wrist mobility.

Now we will take a look at Maltese variations on a single bar.

SUPINATED GRIP MALTESE ON BAR

That grip can be used on any straight bar or aligned parallel bars. The difficulty of this grip depends a lot from the bar on which you are going to perform Maltese. It depends from the diameter of the bar, also is it wooden, metallic, plastic or with rubber handle. In the most cases just using a chalk may help for plenty of them.



Figure 10.15 – bar grip supinated Maltese

Specifics: 1. The grip is more strength based, instead of joint-resistance based. For this grip is okay if you are aware every time that you are squeezing the bar a bit early in advance, not right in the end, when you are supposed to hold it and to feel the resistance of your grip. Here more vulnerable to stress is the bicep, more than anything else. So be careful and prepared when you start with this variation.

2. You have to be aware about how flexible are your wrists. As you can see on the picture – my wrists aren't the most flexible ones, so I have to maintain a straight line with my wrist in order to use full capacity of my grip.

3. If you think you have more flexible wrists to keep them bent backwards, like closer to false grip – it will be easier for you to control it.

The most important tip – test your wrists flexibility with this grip by applying tension on your hands with some lean forward. You have to feel some kind of pain which you can stand as a beginning.

PRONATED GRIP MALTESE ON BAR

That grip can be used on any straight bar or aligned parallel bars, just like the supinated grip. Grabbing the bar in advance and pulling the wrists forward, while the grip is squeezing as hard as possible, is something fundamental when you start practicing this grip, until your protraction stance and the supporting muscles are strong enough.



Figure 10.16 – bar grip pronated Maltese

Specifics: As we already said – it's truly important to squeeze in advance, before to start the lean. Once we start the lean – the wrist has to have additional space on the bar/parallel bars for moving forward after you twist it with the grip. It's required more time to the elbows to get used to the tension, compared to the other grips.

Think more about putting more bodyweight on the spot between the thumb and the index finger. That makes your grip more grip based, instead of joint based. That detail makes the whole difference – if it's not on point the wrist will stay behind the bar, not above.

NO BAR GRIP MALTESE (SUPINATED)

That grip can be used on any straight bar or aligned parallel bars. There must be prepared some details in advance, before to lean for this Maltese hold.

Specifics:

1. The main thing for which you have to be looking for is to intentionally push up and back, after letting some extra area from your hands to be slid forward, while you are leaning.
2. Keep your hands squeezing in certain position, don't be liquid with your grip.

3. Additional squeeze of between the hand and the thumb is really helpful as well, because that the way to remain holding the parallettes.



Figure 10.17 – no bar grip supinated Maltese

NO BAR GRIP MALTESE (PRONATED)

That grip can be used on any straight bar or aligned parallettes. There must be prepared some details in advance, before to lean for this Maltese hold.



Figure 10.18 – no bar grip pronated Maltese

Specifics:

1. The main thing for which you have to be looking for is to intentionally push up and back, after letting some extra area from your hands to be slid forward, while you are leaning.
 2. Keep your hands squeezing in certain position, don't be liquid with your grip.
 3. Additional squeeze of between the space of thumb and index finger is recommended to keep holding the parallettes.
 4. You may try to feel like you are slightly returning your wrist to straight line position. This intention helped me to hold this variation longer.
-

BAR MALTESE ON WRISTS

Such Maltese variation can be quite painful, but it's all up to your pain threshold or how much your wrists are used to the tension in that single pressure point in the upper wrist area.



Figure 10.19 – bar grip Maltese on inverted wrists

Specific: It can be quite useful when you do it to squeeze your fingers into a fist and to keep your forearm loaded all the time, that will give you additional stability, instead of holding with straight fingers. Another important element of the move is to assist to your wrist by pushing with the fist from below, like that you will be able to spread the tension a bit and it won't be so tough in that single wrist point.



Figure 10.20 – Hand placement on a bar from a side angle

On the picture below is shown with a chalk line where the bar is touching the hand:



Figure 10.15 – bar grip supinated Maltese

Variations on parallettes:

MALTESE ON VERTICAL POLES

One truly iconic, beautiful and easy variation, which is giving you another whole angle of perspective for your Maltese skills and opens many more Maltese opportunities. One of my favorite variations as well. I recommend to anyone who wants to become a static beast to practice this one after mastering the regular Maltese on parallettes.

With thumbs looking down:



Figure 10.16 – vertical poles Maltese (with thumb looking down)

Specifics: The wrist and the thumb have to be directed toward the shoulder during the hold of that variation. That means you have to grab a bit sideways and during the lean into the Maltese attempt to twist the wrists and thumbs a bit inward + your grip as well. That's a natural counter to not fall any lower and you will feel more stable.



Figure 10.17 – vertical poles grip before and after the lean

With neutral thumb's position:

Here as you can see on the picture below – the wrist goes lower in order to keep the body higher. It's possible to do it from pure strength grip, but it appears to be harder.

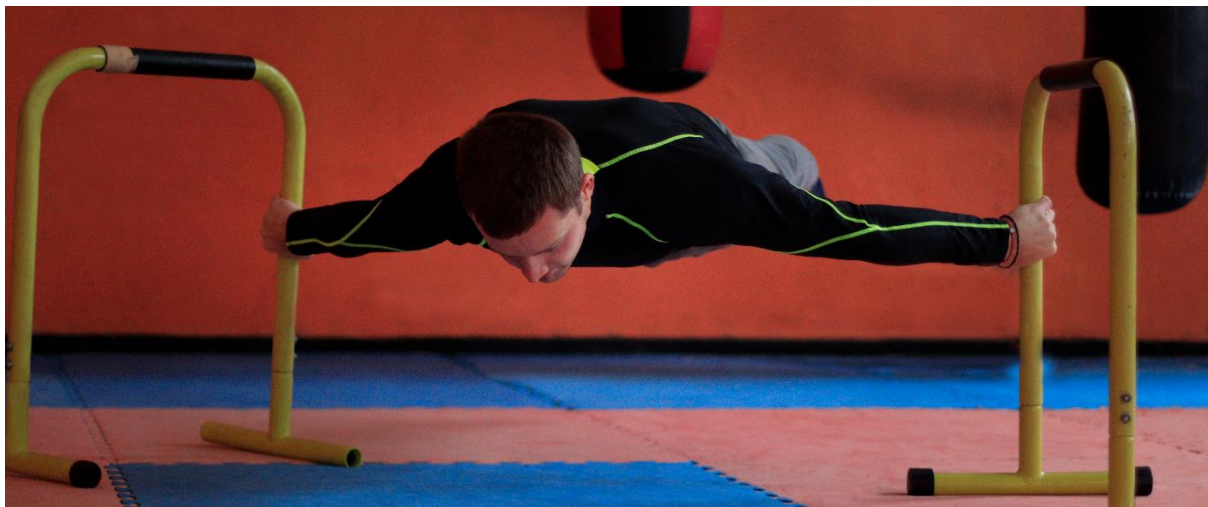


Figure 10.18 – vertical poles Maltese (with neutral thumb position)

Would be great if you aim to place the shoulders just a bit more in front of the chest. Don't aim to be really visible, but keep it in mind as something to aim for. By default the posture for low Maltese is more neutral instead of protracted.

MALTESE ON VERTICAL POLES (INDEX FINGER LOOKING DOWN)

That's a bit harder variation, similar to the previous vertical poles variation. In general it's a bit more painful, because the index finger bone isn't so endurable and strong.



Figure 10.19 – vertical poles Maltese (with index finger looking down)

Specifics: The main part of your hand which is supporting the Maltese hold is on opposite side of the index finger knuckle. It has to be orientated towards your hips, instead to look at the shoulder's direction.

The difference is really decent compared to the thumb looking down variation, because the feeling of your grip squeezing is different – here we squeeze with different hand area and mainly with 3 fingers on the other side, instead with 4. That's why it may take some more time if you want to advance with that variation.

FALSE GRIP MALTESE ON VERTICAL POLES

Definitely the most masochistic Maltese variation I have ever tried and I won't recommend it to be tried, haha. The tension in the wrist is so high so it needs quite a stretching and consistent preparation before going for an attempt.



Figure 10.20 – false grip vertical poles Maltese

Specifics in case #1: Four fingers are playing the biggest role here (without the thumb). All of them have to pull the wrist as close to the vertical pole as possible and then the wrist has to be twisted backward and to apply tension towards the pole. The result is bicep looking downward, because of the twisted wrist. With other words – more biceps stretch and loading than usual.

Specifics in case #2: Four fingers are playing the biggest role here (without the thumb). All of them have to pull the wrist as close to the vertical pole as possible, but the wrist isn't twisting backward, instead of that it's relying more on its own flexibility. The result is more balanced ratio between bicep and shoulder activation.



Figure 10.21 – false grip vertical poles Maltese hand placement

DRAGON MALTESE

Dragon Maltese – in my opinion it became the most used Maltese variation in the last years. Simply because it looks beautiful, a bit challenging for the balance and not so hard in terms of strength. The difficulty of the Dragon Maltese may vary from many factors. First – the parallettes. How heavy are they first, seconds hold long are they and third what's the range on the ground, which they can cover in such position. Second – the floor and how slick is it.

The regular Dragon Maltese can be done in the following ways:

1. **With thumb looking down** – that technique is based on vertical poles Maltese, so if you are truly used to it probably that's the best option for you. The thumb assist allows a great support and stability, like for the vertical poles, but it takes a decent part from the wrist mobility. Which won't allow you to balance the parallette too backwards with the back part of the hand.



Figure 10.22 – Dragon Maltese with thumbs looking down

2. **With thumb squeezing below the other fingers** – that technique is based on regular Maltese on vertical poles. If you work more on regular Maltese on parallettes and you don't have quite an experience with the vertical poles grip – this one suits you. This grip does not allow stability like the other grip, but it allows you to keep your wrists mobile. You have to adapt to push the parallette harder on the front side with the space on the palm, which stands between the index finger and the thumb.

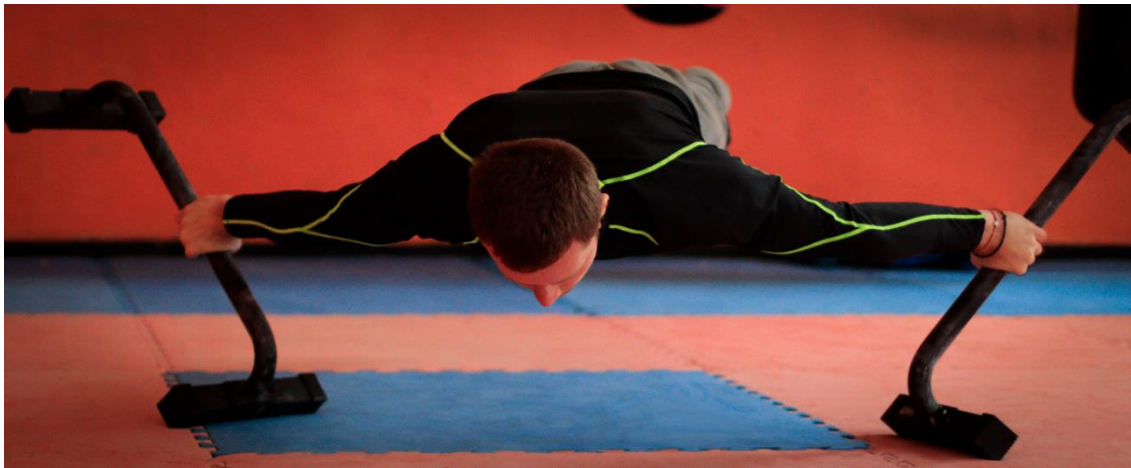


Figure 10.23 – Dragon Maltese with thumbs squeezing below

	Advantages	Negatives
With thumb looking down	Great for longer holds.	Not suitable for dragon Maltese combinations.
	You can control it on any height parallette.	
With thumb squeezing below	Easier combinations once you understand how to control the type of grip.	Less hold possibilities, if you are used to the vertical poles.

KATANA GRIP MALTESE ON VERTICAL POLES

Here we meet another dangerous variation. It's dangerous, because you have to be sure to be prepared with your stretching for arms not on 100%, but on 200%. I'm saying it in that way so to be easier to understand how much you expose on risk the wholeness of the bicep tendons.



Figure 10.24 – Katana grip Maltese

Specifics: This oversupinated grip requires the parallettes to be pushed, instead to be pulled towards the body. The reason is that this angle of supination puts a lot of strain of the elbows and if you try to pull the parallettes with this grip – the pain much more.

That's why I would recommend you to do this grip on stable parallettes (someone holding them), with a lot of weights on the parallettes or simply on suitable place which can't be moved.

STANCHEV MALTESE

I would say – the hardest back lever at first glance. Some people describe it as reverse Victorian cross. I would say the hardest back lever, because the grip is allowing you mainly to pull. You have to pull so much, unless you transform it into push-looking element.

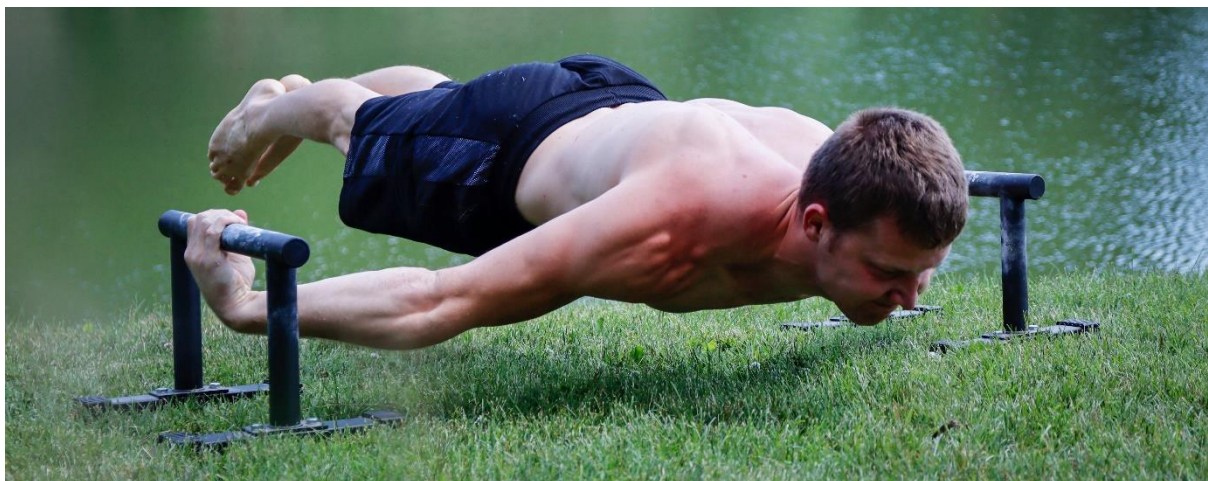


Figure 10.25 – Stanchev grip Maltese

Specifics: Mainly pulling-type grip, which requires the tensility of the wrists to be executed. **You count it for Maltese if the shoulder is reaching the wrist level or above.** This time we watch the wrist, because that's the place which directs your arm higher, it's not the grip.

It's important to not forget to pull the parallettes towards your body and to push yourself upward. The direction of your lean depends from your level. If you are just stepping into this variation – probably will be good to lean forward, just to be easier to reach the required Maltese level. Later when you get a better feeling of your Maltese – try to improve your control by pulling the lean back (backward).

STANCHEV MALTESE ON VERTICAL POLES

This grip requires 90 degrees additional grip rotation, compared to the regular Stanchev Maltese on parallel bars. Here the question is – can you apply your strength with so extreme grip rotation and yes, it's as you think – it's dangerous. It's not so recommended variation for casual performing anywhere.



Figure 10.26 – Stanchev grip Maltese on vertical poles

Specifics: Requires specific low parallel bars, at least for me the Gornation parallel bars were working with the attempts for that Maltese. Here we mix the balance of the Dragon Maltese with the required strength for Stanchev Maltese, which easily leads to Maltese with high fail percentage.

The parallel bars have to be placed just like for Dragon Maltese and just like for the Stanchev Maltese – you have to pull with the fingers the parallel bars towards your body and to push them aside at the same time. Balance is really tough.

DRAGON MALTESE ABOVE PARALLETES

Like technique – it's nothing different from the regular Dragon Maltese. You just have to be careful when you place the parallettes.



Figure 10.27 – Dragon Maltese above parallettes

Specifics: Pay attention for the surface on which you are going to place your parallettes. At least one of the parallettes has to have rubber coverage. Either the on the bases of the higher-staying parallette or on the handle of the lower-staying parallette. It's not necessary to be as I say, but that gives you stability and way more safety.

Also don't place the higher-staying parallette right in the center of the circle of the other parallette. Like That it will be really easy to slip and to fall. Place it a bit from the other side of the center of the circle, which is toward your body.

It can be performed with both grip – with thumbs looking down and with thumbs squeezing below. It's up to you.

11. Maltese routines



Level Equipment	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 4	Level 5	Level 6	Level 7	Level 8
Low parallettes (1), Middle parallettes (2), High parallettes (3), Rubber band (4), Dumbbells/discs (5), Rings (6)	5	1/2, 4, 5	1/2, 4	1/2, 4, 5	1/2, 5	1/2, 3, 4	1/2, 4	1/2, 3, 6
Estimated time to complete the workout	50 minutes – 1 hour and half							

Level 1: Preparation for the Maltese basics

At this level – people tendons are still not strong enough to take fully the maltese basics loading and they may end up with too slow workout frequency, caused by muscle soreness or just feeling uncomfortable pain in the tendons. That's why they have to start to prepare themselves better. Here's a template of workout of that kind. This level is prepared for people who have 4 – 5 seconds of straddle planche, who is still not mastered. If you feel more confident in your planche skills (like achieved full planche – good line, without mastered protraction for example) – I would recommend you to do this routine only for 1 week and then to step on the next level.

This level is suitable for people who are right in the beginning of their planche journey, who want to keep it up with Maltese workouts in the same time.

1. 3 sets x Option 1: 12 seconds hold – Maltese grip push against the wall.

Option 2: 12 seconds hold – Maltese with hands on higher surface, feet on the floor.

Note for Option 1: In standing position, width of the hands – that much like you image your maltese position currently. Distance from the wall 2, 2 and half or 3 feet distance, it's your choice, based on how it will be better for you to push with the feet towards the wall.

Note for **Option 2**: With feet on the floor and hands somewhere on the knee's level in standing position. The method is the same like for the Option 1. The body position is the same, just we are against the gravity. I recommend it if you feel Option 1 as easy and not challenging.

- Rest between sets: 2 minutes.



2. 3 sets x 6 reps - Wide grip push up + slight Maltese lean forward.

Note: Hands and feet on the floor. Grip – twice the shoulder's width. Your fingers must look sideways during the set. Be sure you finish the push up with protraction and keep protracting more with the lean forward. When you do the leans – bring them back only from your arm strength, don't cheat with the lower back pull (anterior pelvic tilt pull).

- Rest between sets: 2 minutes.



3. 4 sets x Option 1: 5 reps – Typewriter push ups.

Option 2: 5 reps – Archer push ups.

Note: Hands and feet on the floor. Grip – twice the shoulder's width. Your fingers must look sideways during the set. When you perform the exercise – your extended arm must lead the exercise, not the bent one. We have to prepare the strength of the straight arm. **That applies for the both options.**

- Rest between sets: 2 minute.



4. 4 sets x 10 reps – straight arms dumbbell lifts in laid position.

Note: Take suitable weight dumbbells (4 – 8 kg). It's named lifts instead of raises, because you have to literally lift the dumbbells from the ground, while you are in laid position. They have to be risen slightly above the shoulders level.

- Rest between sets: 2 minutes.



5. 3 sets x 5 reps – Push up position (Maltese grip, without lean) - retraction and protraction switches.

Note: Hands and feet on the floor. Grip – twice the shoulder's width. Your fingers must look sideways during the set. For this level is not required a lean

forward. Start from protracted position and retract by letting your chest in front of your shoulders (you shouldn't apply strength for that). After that push back into protraction again and repeat it, until you reach you finish the set. Hold in both positions for 2 seconds.

- Rest between sets: 2 minutes.



*Indicator for the next level – you are able to lean close to the actual Maltese lean level with close grip for Maltese lean, without any discomfort or pain in the elbow tendons during the lean.

Level 2: Close grip Maltese lean

After the preparational level here is the next step – to strengthen both your muscles and tendons with Maltese leans.

1. 3 sets x 5 seconds - Straddle Maltese hold with rubber band assistance around the waist.

Note: On parallelles. Take suitable rubber band (it might be the widest one you have at that state). Place the rubber somewhere high and the other rubber band end – place it around your waist. Increase the protraction during the raise and with each centimeter lean forward. It's important to keep it as habit – the more you lean, the more you have to protract.

- Rest between sets: 2 minutes.



2. 3 sets x 6 reps - Wide grip push up + increased Maltese lean forward.

Note: It's the same like seconds exercise from Level 1, but with increased difficulty (the lean level). Hands and feet on the floor. Grip – twice the shoulder's width. Your fingers must look sideways during the set. Be sure you finish the push up with protraction and keep protracting more with the lean forward. When you do the leans – bring them back only from your arm strength, don't cheat with the lower back pull (anterior pelvic tilt pull).

- Rest between sets: 2 minutes.



3. 4 sets x Maltese lean + 5 reps – micro push ups (slow).

Note: Hands and feet on the floor. Grip – twice the shoulder's width. Protracted posture. Your fingers must look sideways during the set. Lean forward, but not your max. Start unlocking your elbows with small push ups and locking them back, do it with slow rhythm. Be sure you finish each micro push up with protraction after each lock back.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute and half.



4. 4 sets x 8 reps – 90 degrees bicep curl + extended arms in laid position with dumbbells.

Note: Take suitable weight dumbbells (4 – 8 kg). Lay on the ground and take the dumbbells. Lift then and keep your elbow 90 degrees bent. Keep the elbow static all the time right above the ribs. **Slowly** extend the arms, until they are fully straight and hold for 2 seconds in this position. After that bent your arms in the same position and repeat. The shoulder should stay in front of the chest and depressed lower.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute and half.



5. 3 sets x 5 reps – max wide protraction from the floor in push up position.

Note: Lay with face against the ground and take the widest grip stance you can lift from the ground. Your fingers must look sideways. Raise your body with push up from the ground. During the push up you have to be retracted so when you raise the push up – to switch into protraction. You don't need a lean level here. The purpose of this exercise is to make us used to the width, while we are strengthening the protraction stance.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute and half.



BONUS EXERCISE:

6. 3 sets x 10 seconds hold – Maltese lean hold on forearms (straight bar).

Note: It can be done on middle parallettes. Legs on the floor. Choose where to place your forearms on the parallettes. It can be at the middle of the forearm or at the upper part, closer to the bicep. It's helping if you squeeze hands into fist. Like that it feels like your arms are shorter and it's way easier to hold Maltese like that.

- Rest between sets: 2 minutes.



Level 3: Increasing the width of the Maltese lean

1. 3 sets x 5 seconds - Full Maltese hold with rubber band assistance on the feet.

Note: On parallettes. Take suitable rubber band (15-30 kgs resistance). Place the rubber somewhere high and the other rubber band end – place it around your feet. Increase the protraction during the raise and with each centimeter lean forward. It's important to keep it as habit – the more you lean, the more you have to protract. Here we place it on the feet, to start feeling more the lower back and to control ourselves the Maltese line.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



2. 4 sets x combo: 5 explosive wide push ups + 5 maltese leans + 5 seconds maltese lean hold.

Note: Everything has to be done on the floor. Fingers are looking sideways from the body all the time. Control the protraction all the time as well.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



3. 4 sets x 4 maltese leans with increasing width with each lean.

Note: On the floor, fingers looking sideways from the body. Start the first lean with normal maltese grip width and each next lean has to be done with one fist wider than the previous one.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



4. **4 sets x 4 times combo: 3 rubber band raises in laid position + 3 seconds hold in maltese position.**

Note: Laid on the floor. Take a suitable rubber band and place the middle behind your legs (right below your butt) and grab both of the edges. Start raising the rubber band for quick 3 reps. Hold for 3 seconds when you reach Maltese position with the arms that feels challenging, after the 3rd rep.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



5. **3 sets x 5 reps – maltese lean with max protracted form + 2 seconds hold.**

Note: Both hands and feet – on the floor. Fingers are looking sideways. Start in wide push up position and during the lean push the chest high as much as you can and depress the shoulders in the same time. Hold in your current max leaned position with max protracted form for 2 seconds.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



BONUS EXERCISE:

6. **3 sets x 3 times in one set: close Maltese to wide Maltese.**

Note: On floor, keep the same level of lean and by pulling with your fingers aside from the body – move your hands sideways, so your maltese to become wider. Hold for 2 seconds in the end if it's possible.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



Level 4: Increasing the depth of the Maltese lean

1. **3 sets x 3 straddle Maltese push ups with rubber band around the waist.**

Note: On low/middle parallelles. Tie the rubber band on higher place (for example on the doorframe or bar). Place the rubber band around the waist and when you go for the attempt with the rubber band like that – keep yourself less leaned as possible and watch wrists to be above the parallelles, not sideways. During the push ups keep increasing the tension in your arms, in the protraction as well, don't lose it. Constantly increase the tension.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



2. 3 sets x 4 times combo – Maltese hold with forehead assistance + raising the lean back.

Note: Lay on the ground and place the forehead on the floor as assistance, the same way you are using your feet. Place your fingers to look sideways, as always, align your body, protract the scapula and start to push until you feel less placed bodyweight on your forehead. Keep in mind your neck has to be extended meanwhile, otherwise the stretch in the trapezoid won't be the same. That means – rely on your forehead, but still your sign must be towards the floor. When you feel comfortable like that – start to push higher, until the forehead isn't touching the floor. Repeat it a few times.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



3. 3 sets x 4 reps – Maltese lean + slowly increasing the depth to the ground.

Note: It's your choice – on the floor or on parallelles. With other words – Maltese lean with controlled protraction and everything, BUT when it gets truly hard to maintain the form – to fall on the floor as slow as you can. Falling, but still keeping the push.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



4. 3 sets x actual Maltese lean + 6 switches between protraction and retraction.

Note: With feet on the floor, your choice on parallelles or on the floor. The goal is to make max close Maltese lean as it has to be, when you are doing Maltese attempt. Start from protracted position and retract your scapula, by letting the chest to go lower, don't push it additionally. After that bring it back to lean protracted position. Watch out for the neck's position. When you protract it has to be extended and watching toward the lean's direction.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



5. 4 sets x 10 reps – Maltese grip dumbbells raises in laid position.

Note: Take 2 dumbbells with suitable weight (5-10kg). Lay on the floor and it's your choice – you may keep raised your legs centimeters from the ground, engaging your core or just to remain fully laid, focused on the upper part. It will be better for you to decide for your weaknesses and strong sides. Then start raising the dumbbells from there by keeping the shoulders width all the time. Do it with controlled pace - not too slow, not too fast. Activate the bicep additionally, just to not let that much pressure to fall at your elbow joints. Hold for 2 seconds in the both positions.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



BONUS EXERCISE:

6. 3 sets x 3 reps – maltese depth pull + lean back.

Note: On parallettes, feet on the floor. Hold Maltese lean at the level where you imagine you can hold a high Maltese. During the hold – pull the lean lower, just to reach deeper level, hold for a second and bring it back.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



Level 5: Attempts on the stage! (Bad form straddle Maltese)

In the first 4 levels we covered everything we need to start with attempts right there. After practicing this level the way it's explained in the notes and in the book part – the estimated time to be ready for the next level is up to one month.

1. 3 sets x straddle Maltese hold with low level legs position (attempt).

Note: On middle parallettes. Before to raise your body – place your feet next to the parallettes and point your feet (raise the heel and stand on your toes). Raise your legs and fully extend them during the hold (lock the knees), it's okay if your toes are under the grip's level, keep holding there. Test are you able to hold it freely for 5 seconds at least. Don't over activate the lower back. **Do this routine until you reach 10 seconds hold on this exercise.**

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



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2. 4 sets x 2 – 4 reps – low to high level legs raises during Maltese hold (attempt).

Note: On middle parallelles will be truly suitable for this exercise, because you will feel the legs better. Place your feet next to the parallelles and point your feet (raise the heel and stand on your toes). Raise your feet and keep the lower back stable, try to keep it fully static. When the legs are already raised – move them a bit forward, then fully extend them (lock the knees) and swing backwards until you reach straddle form, straight line. You are not supposed to hold it there, but just to reach the form. You may step on the floor after each rep or to constantly stay on your arms, until you finish the set. Once again – the main goal is to keep the lower back truly static.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



3. 2 x 1 drop set: 1st set: 8 controlled Maltese leans (rest – 30 seconds). 2nd set: 6 controlled Maltese leans (rest – 25 seconds). 3rd set: 4 controlled Maltese leans (rest – 20 seconds). 4th set: 2 controlled Maltese leans.

Note: On floor/on parallelles – your choice. Feet on the floor. Controlled speed leans. Keep the bicep activated, support the protraction, extend the neck forward and don't bring the leans back from the lower back, but from the arms.

- Rest between drop sets: 2 minutes.



4. 3 sets x 4 - 6 reps – Leaned Maltese grip push ups.

Note: On floor/on parallelles – your choice. Feet on the floor. Width – not too wide, twice the width of the shoulders is enough. Keep yourself protracted and not so leaned. Do the push ups with controlled speed and maintain the protraction the whole time, also watch out for the grip (wrist level) – it has always to be above the parallelle, not on it's level.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



5. 4 sets x 10 reps – Maltese grip dumbbells raise + retraction/protraction in laid position.

Note: Take suitable dumbbells for the exercise. Start the raises with extended elbows and activated bicep, protracted position. When you reach 90 degrees raise (right above the head) – touch the floor with the dumbbells (retract), protract again and slowly negative back to main position.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



Level 6: Visible progress! (Perfect form straddle Maltese)

1. 3 sets x perfect straddle Maltese hold (attempt).

Note: On parallettes. Before to raise your body – place your feet next to the parallettes and point your feet (raise the heel and stand on your toes). Fully extend your feet into perfect straddle Maltese attempt. Test are you able to hold it freely for 3 seconds at least. Don't over activate the lower back, rely on the trapezoid, protraction and shoulders. **Do this routine until you reach 6 seconds hold on this exercise.**

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



2. 3 sets x 3 times combo: 2 seconds Maltese hold + Maltese pike press with rubber band.

Note: On parallettes. Place the rubber band on your feet. Do the combination with full form. Pay attention on the trapezoid activation and neck position

during the switch, also in Maltese position the trapezoid has to be felt as the highest activated point of your body.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



3. 3 sets x 80% max hold - straddle Maltese hold on forearms (straight bar).

Note: On middle/high parralletes or any bar. Place your forearms on parralletes/bar, you choose exactly where on the forearm (depends what difficulty is suitable for you). The goal is to feel you arm shorter and to make the Maltese control easier. Start with protraction and push the forearms against the parralletes to raise the Maltese, don't lean additionally forward. Advantage may give you squeezing your hand into fist.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



4. 3 sets x 3 - 6 reps - max deep controlled Maltese leans.

Note: With feet on floor/hands on parralletes or floor – it's your choice. Here each the repetition has to be controlled and to reach as low as you can and your goal will be to maintain the protracted stance all the time, by increasing the tension there. Will be important to increase the tension with each centimeter forward, that's how control strength is done and how control is mastered.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



5. 4 sets x 90% max reps - Rubber band pushes in standing position.

Note: Take suitable rubber band. Catch the both edge spots of the rubber band with your hands and place the middle below your butt. Protract your shoulders forward and keep them there all the time. Activate your bicep and start with doing the reps. Hold 2 seconds when you reach the hardest spot forward.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



BONUS EXERCISE:

One great way to prepare your legs is to

6. 4 sets x 2 reps – man split 10 seconds hold + maltese lean with feet in that position.

Note:

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



Level 7: Almost there! (Straddle Maltese hold + closing to full Maltese)

1. 3 sets x straddle Maltese hold to full Maltese (attempt).

Note: On parallelles. Start holding straddle Maltese and when you feel your body fixed and controlled in this position – close your legs to full Maltese. The form is not necessary to be perfect try to hold it for 2-3 seconds and to go back to straddle Maltese. It's okay if your lower back swallow the shape lower, it's important to get used to the tension. **Do this routine until you are able to hold 3 seconds with perfect full Maltese form, with which you are satisfied after the straddle Maltese hold.**

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



2. 3 sets x 3 reps - straddle Maltese hold to full Maltese with rubber band.

Note: On parallelles. Place the rubber band around your waist. Here the goal is to make more reps of the first exercise, but with less tension by using the assistance of a suitable for you rubber band.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



3. 3 sets x straddle Maltese hold with tension on the wrists (attempt).

Note: Do the attempt on floor. The idea of this attempt is to shorten your arm by placing the tension of the bodyweight closer to the wrists. Making an attempt in the 3rd exercise for the first time is aiming to improve your

endurance with lower difficulty. Aim to keep the straddle Maltese as high as possible, max protracted.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



4. 4 sets x 2 reps - straddle Maltese elevation: high – low – high.

Note: On parallettes. Use suitable rubber band. Tie it on your waist. We have already seen something similar on that as bonus exercise in level 4 - “**maltese depth pull + lean back**”. The difference is – we have to do it straddle attempt now with rubber band assistance. The focus has to be on switching the protraction with retraction and back to protracted stance.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



5. 4 sets x 20 seconds - Maltese lean hold with increasing protraction on each 5 seconds.

Note: Use parallettes or on floor – your choice. Feet on the floor. Start with protracted Maltese lean position and on each 5 seconds you have to increase the tension in your protraction, bicep, trapezoid, grip. With other words – make it yourself struggle more on each 5 seconds, by applying additional tension. The only thing you have to be careful – don’t increase the tension in the lower back at the same rate as you do for your protraction, that will make your form too high in the lower back/glutes area.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



Level 8: The dream comes true! (Full Maltese hold)

1. 3 sets x full Maltese attempt.

Note: On parallettes or on floor – your choice. Keep attention all the time about the grip, bicep activation, neck position, protraction and so on. Just

repeat it a few times before the attempt. Going straight for full Maltese for first time might be a bit challenging.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



2. 3 sets x 3 – 6 reps – Leaned Maltese raises from the floor with locked elbows.

Note: On floor, feet on the ground the whole time. In laid position you have to lift your body from the ground and to finish in leaned Maltese hold, with feet on the floor. It's important when you place your hands to not be that much wide – feel first how much lean you will need after the lift and then retract your shoulders. Your fingers have to look sideways from the body. When you raise your body the main focus is as quick as you can to feel how the trapezoid is activation, the bicep and grip has to support it and from this point – do your best to protract from this position. When you get comfortable with this exercise start to switch the starting point to more protracted instead of retracted. This process is linked with the strength which will come later with the practice.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



3. 3 sets x 4 times combo: (1) Maltese lean + (2) Maltese pike press + (3) back into Maltese lean + (4) negative Maltese push up + (5) bring the negative back + (6) wide push up.

Note: Here's one of my favorite combos, which is for overall strengthening. I'm applying full planche variation of this exercise as well. You can use parallettes or straight on the floor – your choice. **(1) During the Maltese lean** the neck has to be extended forward and you have to look towards the direction of your lean. When you bring the lean back **(2) Maltese position pike press** – flex the feet and point them, you have to aim to make the distance between the arms and the legs as short as possible. Then bring back your neck between the shoulders (don't keep it extended). The final position of the lower back has to be right above your shoulders, making a straight vertical line. When you lean forward again to **(3) Maltese lean position** - extend again your neck and look towards the direction of your lean. Aim to keep shoulders max engaged and slightly protracted when you do **(4) the negative Maltese push up**. The remaining part is to **(5) pull yourself backward**, that will remove the lean and finish with **(6) wide protracted push up**.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



4. 3 sets x 4 – 6 reps - assisted Zanetti push ups (each arm).

Note: Here you will need a vertical bar or middle parallelte. If you are on middle parallelte – you can grab it with neutral grip, if you have higher vertical pole – vertical pole grip (with the thumb looking downward). Keep that arm fully extended. The other arm has to assist from the floor, in push up position. Start doing push ups by placing more of your bodyweight onto the straight arm, which is on the parallelte/vertical pole. The idea is to get used to any kind of lean level and to control it. That's why you have to do it with both arms.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



5. 4 sets x 4 times combo: 3 seconds Maltese lean hold + lean back.

Note: On paralleltes or straight on the floor – your choice. Hold 80% max deep Maltese lean for 3 seconds and lean back to main position. Repeat it 4 times in one set.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.



BONUS EXERCISE:

6. 3 sets x 4 reps – ring fly drills with feet on the shoulder's level.

Note: Here you will need pair of rings. The rings and the place where you are about to place your feet is recommended to be on the same level. Start from leaned push up position by supinating the rings and go slowly lower until you reach Maltese lean in that position, hold for 2 seconds and pull the rings closer so you go back to main position. It's important to keep pulling the rings towards your body all the time, otherwise your hands will be shaking.

- Rest between sets: 1 minute.

